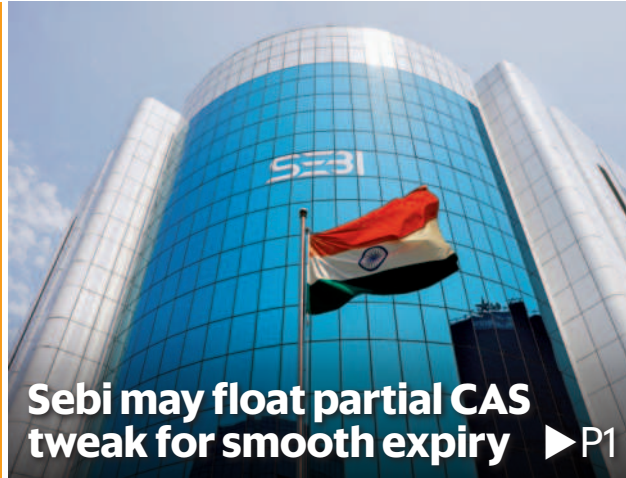


Monday, September 7, 2026

mint

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Sebi may float partial CAS tweak for smooth expiry ▶ P1



Local private credit funds beat foreign peers in mid-market ▶ P1



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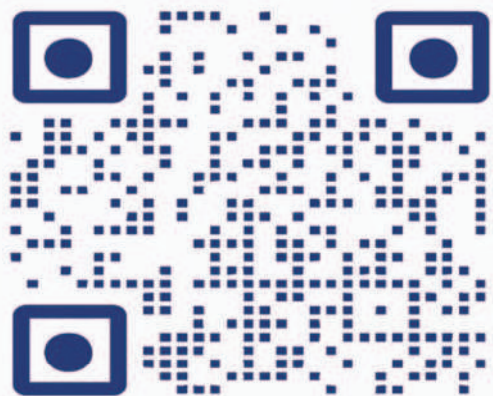
Highlights

FREE FILM SCREENINGS

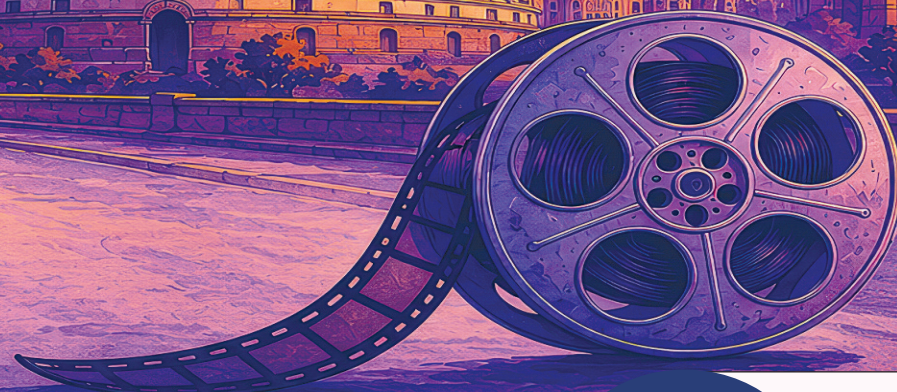
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Monday, September 7, 2026

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Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Why the era of cheap money is coming to an end

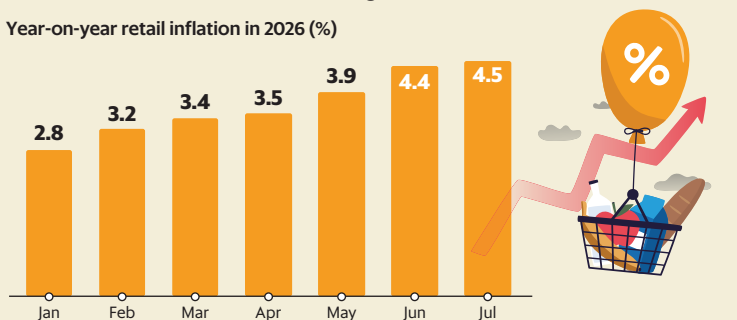
BY N. MADHAVAN

For almost two decades, governments, businesses and households the world over benefitted from low borrowing costs. If words and actions of many central banks are anything to go by, that could well be coming to an end. *Mint* explains why the era of cheap money is ending.

On the rise

In June, inflation breached RBI's 4% target for the first time in 16 months.

Year-on-year retail inflation in 2026 (%)



Source: Statistics ministry

mint

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

1 How long have interest rates been low?

The period of low, or even ultra-low, interest rates began after the 2008 financial crisis. Most developed nations cut interest rates sharply to revive the economy and ensured massive liquidity through quantitative easing. Interest rates in the US remained near zero for seven years after the financial crisis till 2015, and again for two years post the pandemic. In the euro zone, borrowings costs were below 1% since 2009 and fell below 0% in 2015 before turning positive in 2022. The interest cost in Japan was below 0.5% since 1996, entered the negative zone in 2016, and remained there till 2024.

BLOOMBERG



2 But what has changed in the outlook now?

Moody's Ratings, in a recent report, said a new macroeconomic regime is driving differentiated repricing across financial assets, and at the heart of this shift is a move towards higher interest rates. Last month, yields on 30-year US Treasury bonds touched their pre-2008 financial crisis levels, signalling a return to a more expensive funding scenario. This is because rising government debt and AI and energy linked investments are fanning competition for funds. An era of higher rates, that Moody's sees sustaining for long, will force governments, businesses and households to re-look how much debt they can service.

3 Have central banks started raising interest rates?

Yes. The Bank of Japan increased its policy rate by 25 basis points (bps) in June and is expected to hike it by another 25 bps at its 16 September meeting, taking the rate to 1.25%. The European Central Bank is also expected to hike its interest rate on 10 September by 25 bps to 2.25%, as euro zone inflation has hit 3.3%, much higher than its 2% target.

4 What about the rate scenario in the US?

On 28 August, Federal Reserve chair Kevin Warsh set a hawkish tone at his debut Jackson Hole keynote address, reaffirming the Fed's commitment to its 2% inflation aim. Inflation has stayed above that level for over five years now. In July, it was 3.4%. The case for a rate hike rose after August job data showed a sharp hiring jump. But President Donald Trump has already warned against such a move, as mid-term polls are up in November. The August inflation number, due on 11 September, could be the clinching factor.

5 So, will interest rates rise in India too?

For the first time in 16 months, retail inflation in India topped RBI's target of 4% to touch 4.4% in June due to higher food and energy prices. Inflation is seen at 5.9% in Q3. Though RBI's monetary policy panel left the policy rate unchanged at 5.25% at its August meeting, its members are veering towards a possible hike later this year. They have suggested recalibration of policy rates if prices remain elevated and inflation hardens. They are awaiting more clarity on global developments and weather-related risks.

QUICK EDIT

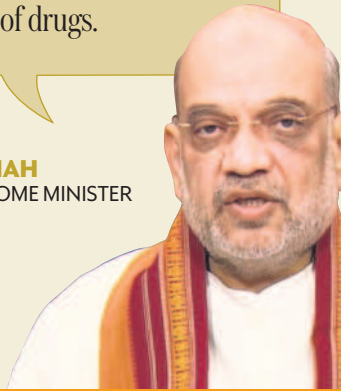
The clean fuel shift

A 16% year-on-year rise in passenger vehicle sales in August helps explain cheerful faces in India's automobile sector. But there's a more impressive trend afoot. Research by Equirus Securities confirms what was observed earlier too: a big shift in energy preferences among buyers away from petrol to cleaner CNG and electricity. Hybrid and electric vehicles (EVs) have been rolling onto the streets in fast-rising numbers. Together, these three categories accounted for 42% of sales last month, overtaking the 41% share of petrol vehicles, which fell from 46% a year earlier. Category-wise, the share of CNG vehicles expanded to 25% in August from 21% a year earlier and that of EVs to 7.7% from 5.9%, although the EV share shrank a bit from 8.1% in July. Broadly, however, adoption of clean fuels seems to be on an upward trend. Some of this may be down to anxieties around ethanol-mixed petrol in the wake of an oil shock, but the EV-versus-hybrid choice will depend on how quickly India expands battery-charging ports. Hybrids, which don't need to be plugged in, are a bridge to fully electric road mobility, a worthy goal. India's charging networks clearly need to grow faster.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

The way Naxalism was eliminated from the country, the Union government will similarly eliminate the menace of drugs.

AMIT SHAH
UNION HOME MINISTER



INSIDE

- Mark to Market | CAS fear grips BSE investors >P4
- Global | Iran says it will deal with US sanctions >P8
- Money | Could data-driven mutual funds make better stock picks for you? >P11
- Views | Economics 101: mauled again by Donald Trump >P12
- Views | Student protests have put India's welfare economy under the lens >P13

THE WEEK AHEAD

7 SEP RBI VRRR AUCTION

RBI's 30-day VRRR auction to absorb ₹7 trillion surplus liquidity.

7 SEP NSE PRE-OPEN RULES

NSE to change pre-open session rules from 7 September.

7-11 SEP IPOs THIS WEEK

Multiple issues including Manipal Payment, Rentomojo this week.

8 SEP CANADA-US TARIFFS

Canada to impose retaliatory tariffs on US as trade war escalates.

9 SEP APPLE EVENT

'Surprise and Shine' event expected to unveil iPhone 18 lineup.

12-13 SEP BRICS SUMMIT

India to host 18th Brics Summit in Delhi.

COLUMNS



MYTHILI BHUSNURMATH
OH, FOR A FEW DOLLARS LESS:
RBI IS FACED WITH A FOREX
FLOOD >P13

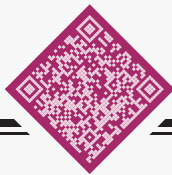


Nitin
Pai
WHY INDIAN
LANGUAGES DEMAND
STANDARD ROMAN
TRANSLITERATION >P12

David
Fickling
NUCLEAR SHIPPING
MUST NOT BE TURNED
INTO ANOTHER
ARMS RACE



>P13



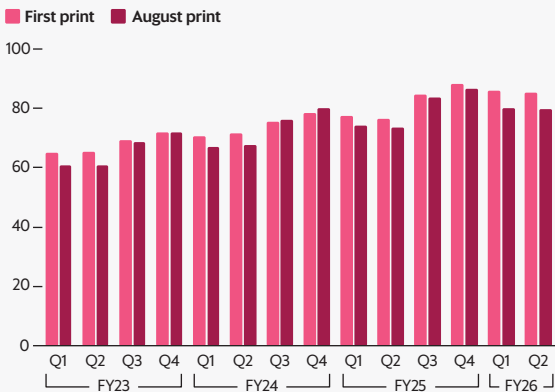
WHY INDIA GDP DATA IS FACING TRUST GAP

BY PRAGYA SRIVASTAVA

India's updated gross domestic product (GDP) methodology addresses past statistical issues, but downward nominal revisions and the sudden inclusion of the Producer Price Index raise credibility concerns.

New and improved GDP math makes Indian economy smaller than previously thought

Nominal GDP value (in ₹ trillion)



First print refers to the figure reported two months after a quarter ended, and the August print refers to figures released on 31 August 2026.

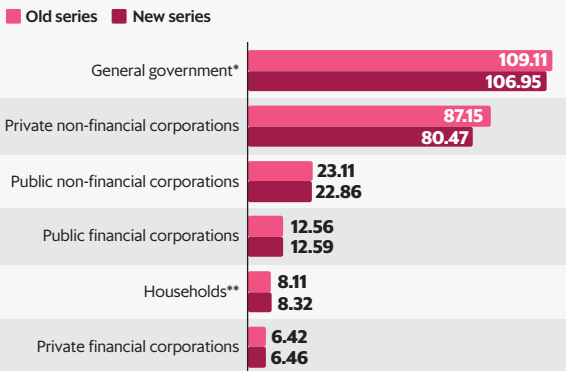
Revised GDP series addresses some data quality concerns raised by the IMF

Issues raised by the IMF in Nov 2025	Does new series address them?
Outdated base year	Yes. The base year has been updated to 2022-23 from 2011-12 after a gap of 10 years.
Use of WPI data; excessive use of single deflation	Somewhat. The new series has introduced double deflation for the manufacturing sector and incorporated the PPI, which is only available at the output level.
Sizeable discrepancies	No. GDP data continues to show high discrepancies (mismatches between estimates from the production and expenditure sides). In recent quarters, discrepancies were around 1.4% of GDP.
Lack of seasonally adjusted data	No. Statistics ministry has not started releasing seasonally adjusted data yet.

Source: Statistics ministry, Data for India, International Monetary Fund, Mint research

Non-financial private corporate accounted for most decline in new GDP series

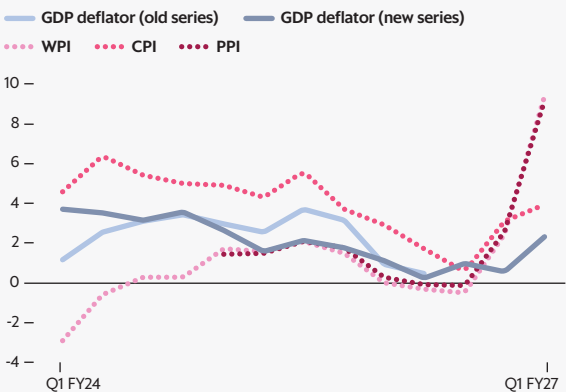
Gross value added in 2022-23 (in ₹ trillion), major institutional sectors



*Includes Union, state, local governments, and autonomous bodies.
**Includes all unincorporated enterprises and non-profit institutions serving households (NPISH). Quasi-corporations are excluded.

The new deflator has largely tracked broader price trends in the past three years

Year-on-year change (in %)



Over the last few days, India's gross domestic product (GDP) figures have come under fresh scrutiny for two reasons: downward revisions to past nominal values and a lack of transparency regarding the use of the deflator (the difference between real and nominal GDP due to inflation). While most experts believe that the shift to the new base year 2022-23 in February has addressed several issues that existed in the previous 2011-12 series, a lack of full information on several fronts, especially the rapid inclusion of the Producer Price Index (PPI) in the GDP calculations, is a good enough reason to be sceptical about the numbers.

A SMALLER ECONOMY

After more than a decade of questions over the reliability of India's GDP estimates, the government introduced a new methodology in 2026, with a range of changes aimed at improving data quality.

These include greater use of current data from surveys for estimation of the unorganized sector, a shift towards the double deflation method for the manufacturing sector, and the use of supply-use data to reduce discrepancies between GDP estimated from the production and expenditure approaches. The changes address several gaps flagged by the International Monetary Fund (IMF), which had assigned the country's national accounts a 'C' rating, indicating that the data had "some shortcomings that somewhat hamper surveillance".

The downward revision of ₹6 trillion in Q1 FY26, or around ₹9 trillion in full FY25, is the result of significant corrections to overestimations that occurred under the old series.

According to an analysis by data and research platform Data for India, the non-financial private corporate sector accounted for most of the decline in the new GDP estimates. The estimates for the private corporate sector have been a subject of controversy as they were based on a small sample of companies. In the 2011-12 series, the statistics ministry incorporated the MCA-21 database into GDP calculation, though it faced questions of overestimation of the sector's contribution to the economy.

In the earlier series, an economy-wide Paid-Up Capital (PUC)-based multiplier (or blow-up factor) was used to scale up the estimates for reporting companies to account for the contribution of 'active companies' that had not filed their returns but for which PUC data was available. The new series now applies disaggregated PUC-based multipliers to different types of firms.

While the new series seems to have made a course correction—the statistics ministry did release detailed discussion papers on a new methodology that improves transparency—the acknowledgement from the government has been thin compared to its celebration of strong growth numbers.

The downward revision in past nominal numbers has consequences, as many indicators, such as fiscal deficit and debt, are tracked as a percentage of these figures.

The statistics ministry, which is expected to release a back series of GDP data based on the new series later in the year, will provide a fuller picture of how the economy's size has changed compared with previous estimates over the years.

The downward revisions, though, have led to calls for an acknowledgement from the government of past overestimates and the release of more granular data for independent scrutiny of the numbers.

DEFLATOR DEBATE

In the recent quarter (Q1 FY27), when the GDP deflator stood at 2.3% while retail inflation averaged 3.9% and wholesale inflation 9.4%, its low value raised eyebrows. The statistics ministry explained this was the result of a shift towards the double deflation method, which adjusted input and output prices separately.

This was most prominent in the manufacturing sector, where double deflation, as well as the use of output PPI

AT A GLANCE

- India's revised 2022-2023 GDP methodology addressed longstanding data quality issues, but sudden changes like incorporating the Producer Price Index have raised scepticism.

- Unlike typical base-year updates that expand GDP, new survey data and sector adjustments unexpectedly shrank the total past size of India's economy.

- Significant downward revisions in nominal GDP figures stemmed mainly from previous overestimations within the non-financial private corporate sector's contribution.

- Double deflation isolates input and output price movements separately, preventing heavy wholesale price distortions from skewing real and nominal calculations.

instead of the Wholesale Price Index, has been used (though input PPI would be a better measure, it is currently at a trial stage). At a time when the PPI also stood at around 9%, the manufacturing deflator was -1.4%.

This dichotomy can happen when input prices rise faster than output prices, resulting in a negative deflator. This means that even as prices rose for both producers and consumers, profit margins were squeezed due to higher inputs prices, reflecting less value added at current prices.

According to Abhishek Upadhyay, co-head of research at ICICI Securities Primary Dealership, double deflation is a better method of price adjustments and has corrected distortions that were happening due to the high usage of wholesale prices, particularly for periods when commodity prices were very volatile. "As companies pass on the input costs to consumers, the deflator is expected to rise in the coming quarters," Upadhyay said.

While the shift to double deflation and the incorporation of the PPI, despite Q1's low figure, align with the IMF's recommendations, fresh questions have been raised over the lack of transparency in computing the PPI itself, which the commerce ministry is compiling.

Former chief statistician of India, Pronab Sen, raised questions over the sudden availability of the PPI and its rapid inclusion in GDP calculations. According to Sen, India had been trying to compile the PPI but had not succeeded for close to three decades, as companies were reluctant to share their prices, citing this as part of their competitive strategy. "The PPI is the right measure, but we heard nothing until it suddenly came out; more transparency would have given credibility to the estimates," Sen said.

Sen is correct, as the GDP discussion papers released in late 2025, before the base year revision, made no mention of the PPI. In fact, it only stated that revised indices of wholesale and retail prices and industrial output will be incorporated at a later stage. About eight months later, the PPI was incorporated into the GDP calculation, even though it had only been launched in June, with data available only from April 2023.

To be sure, the government constituted a working group under Niti Aayog member Ramesh Chand in January 2025 to review the compilation of the PPI, and a detailed methodology is available in the public domain.

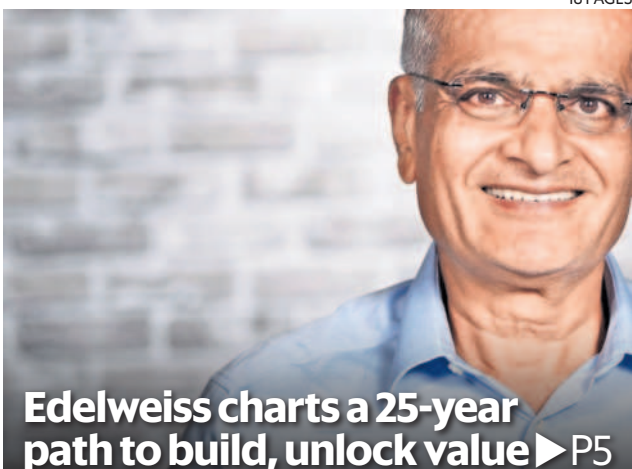
However, the rapid inclusion of the index in the GDP calculation has raised concerns over a lack of scrutiny of data quality.

Rupanjali Chauhan contributed to this story.

Monday, September 7, 2026



Are intercity e-buses having their moment? ▶P10



Edelweiss charts a 25-year path to build, unlock value ▶P5

SENSEX 76,515.43 ↔ 0.00 NIFTY 23,897.70 ↔ 0.00 DOLLAR ₹94.43 ↔ ₹0.00 EURO ₹109.77 ↔ ₹0.00 OIL \$94.92 ↓ \$0.09 POUND ₹127.79 ↔ ₹0.00

Derivatives expiry may see return of old model

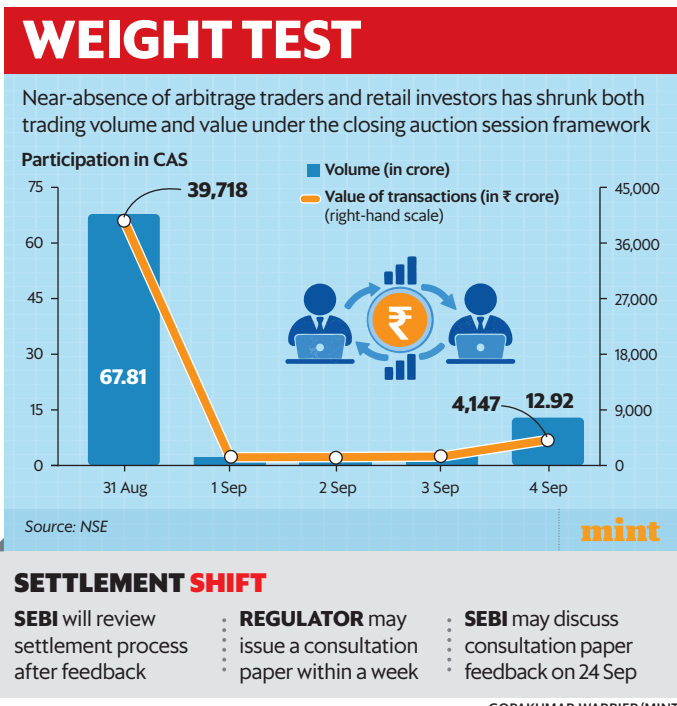
Proposal likely on reviving volume-weighted average or hybrid model on expiry

Ram Sahgal & Apoorva Ajith
MUMBAI

The stock market regulator may look to bring back the old mechanism to settle derivative contracts on expiry days, two people aware of the discussions said, in a partial revision to the closing auction session (CAS) introduced a month ago. The goal is to smooth out last-minute swings on settlement days, which open up gaps between the Nifty and Sensex.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) on Thursday said it will review the settlement process after receiving market feedback and said it may issue a consultation paper on the matter within a week. According to the people cited above, while the daily CAS will continue as before, Sebi may propose settling weekly and monthly derivatives using the previous volume-weighted average price (VWAP) model, or using a combination of VWAP and CAS prices.

"Nifty and Sensex options, which expire on a weekly and monthly basis, can be settled at a 15- or 30-minute VWAP, but the tricky issue is the settlement of stock futures and options, which expire on a monthly basis. The



regulator could use a combination of CAS and VWAP to settle the relevant stocks which are also index constituents," one of the two people mentioned above said on the condition of anonymity.

Derivatives contracts are settled every Tuesday on the National Stock Exchange and every Thursday on the BSE. Before CAS debuted on 3 August, stock and

index derivatives were settled using VWAP—average price an asset has traded at, weighted by how much volume traded at each price—during the last 30 minutes of trading.

However, since CAS was introduced for 213 stocks eligible for derivatives trading, settlement occurred at prices discovered in thinly traded auctions held at

3:15-3:30 pm. Essentially, options contracts with premium value in tens of thousands of crores of rupees were settled based on prices reached in a thinly traded auction of ₹1,200-1,300 crore between NSE and BSE.

A Sebi official was not immediately available for comment. "By distorting the index stock prices during the auction on settlement days, the index options positions taken prior to the auction could swing wildly, causing a divergence between the values of the Nifty and Sensex," the second person said. "Reverting to the VWAP mechanism would obviate price distortions on settlement days while the existing practice can continue on non-settlement days."

The Sebi board meeting on 24 September may discuss public feedback on the consultation paper, the first person added. The price of a derivative is simply the expected spot price on a future date. Based on supply and demand, derivatives normally trade at a premium to spot prices. However, the derivatives price converges with the spot rate at expiry or settlement, when the spread between the two disappears.

With the introduction of CAS,

Local private credit beats foreign peers in mid-market deals

Mansi Verma
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MUMBAI

Indian private credit managers are taking a larger share of mid-market deals as a growing pool of domestic capital gives them an edge over global funds in an increasingly important part of the country's credit market.

Domestic funds accounted for about 74% of private credit deal value and 79% of deal volume in the first half of 2026, according to EY data. The share of global funds plunged to 26% from last year's 68%.

Local funds have an advantage in mid-market deals, where local relationships, rupee funding and faster decision-making can matter as much as financing capacity. Global lenders retain an edge in larger and more complex transactions, where they can deploy bigger pools of capital.

"What we are seeing isn't global capital pulling back from India, but rather domestic capital coming of age," said Eshwar Karra, deputy managing director at Kotak Alternate Asset Managers. Over the past couple of years, Indian private credit has evolved from a niche, opportunistic asset class into a mainstream allocation for domestic limited-part-



Local funds have an advantage in mid-market deals. BLOOMBERG

ners, family offices and high-net-worth individuals, he said.

Funds, including EAAA India Alternatives Ltd, Kotak Alternate Assets Managers Ltd, Ascendis Credit, Avendus PE Investment Advisors and Neo Asset Management, have raised or are targeting about \$4 billion across their private-credit vehicles, according to multiple media reports.

Last month, Motilal Oswal Group committed ₹1,500 crore to Inox Clean Energy Ltd, the renewable energy platform of the INOXGFL Group, in a structured private credit transaction.

The fall in global funds' share needs some context. The first half of 2025 included a

DON'T MISS



Modern Bazaar halves stores as q-comm eats into grocery

Modern Bazaar, one of Delhi-NCR's oldest premium grocery retailers, is restructuring its store network as the rapid rise of quick commerce is forcing traditional supermarkets to rethink the size, location and economics of retail stores. >P7

India working on policy to support ageing population

The Department of Consumer Affairs is working on a framework for the elderly population that seeks to promote their greater participation in the workforce, ensure good-quality care, help staff with caregiving responsibilities, among other measures. >P2

India's average crude oil import price nears \$100/bbl

India's average crude oil import price rose to nearly \$100 a barrel, its highest level in three months, amid renewed volatility in global oil markets, while consumption of key petroleum products such as petrol and diesel also increased. >P6

NOTE TO READERS The Media Marketing Initiative on Page 3 is the equivalent of a paid-for advertisement and no *Mint* journalist was involved in creating it. Readers would do well to treat it as an advertisement.



Darius Khambata of Tata Trusts asked trustees last year to quiz Tata Sons chair on any possible breaches of code of conduct. MINT

An email revives ghost of a Tata Sons clean chit

Varun Sood & Satish John
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

Last year's clean chit given to Tata Sons group company secretary Suprakash Mukhopadhyay, an aide of chairman N. Chandrasekaran, has come under fresh scrutiny. A previously unreported email detailing Mukhopadhyay's role in soliciting an investment for his family's wealth-advisory business raises questions over whether the internal probe that cleared Mukhopadhyay was thorough enough and examined all relevant details.

Darius Khambata, who rejoined the Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT) and the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT) in November 2023 had last year asked Trustees' representatives on Tata Sons board to quiz Chandrasekaran about any possible breaches of the Tata Sons Code of Conduct.

"I think the Trust must ask the chairman of Tata Sons as to whether there has been any breach of the Tata Sons Code of Conduct and what action, if any, is proposed to be taken," Khambata wrote to Tata Trustees on 16 April 2025. "This is a matter for the board of Tata Sons and hence for the Trust nominee directors to raise

after consultation with all the trustees," he wrote.

Mint has reviewed Khambata's email, shared by a Tata group executive.

The email, sent a day after last April's *Mint* report, disclosed how Mukhopadhyay had used his position to get his elder daughter to present the wealth advisory firm to him.

On 15 April 2025, the paper had first reported that Tata Pension Management had listed Divinon Advisory Services Pvt. Ltd, a firm owned by Mukhopadhyay's family, among 473 "Tata Group and sponsor" companies in 2022, before removing the reference a year later. Tata Pension is backed by Tata Asset Management Ltd, where Mukhopadhyay is a director. *Mint*'s story also showed that Mukhopadhyay had not disclosed this business to the group, and had sought help from many current and former group executives.

"I should disclose two things," Khambata wrote in his email. "Mr Mukhopadhyay's daughter, who is a lawyer, is my junior. She joined in September 2023 after graduating. In late 2022, his other daughter, who was working for this

Disputes on arbitration location raise focus on drafting contracts

Krishna Yadav
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NEW DELHI

The fine print in a contract can decide not just how a dispute is fought, but where, and at what cost. Top law firms are urging companies to tighten arbitration clauses in their contracts, as ambiguous drafting triggers disputes over where arbitration should take place and which courts have jurisdiction.

Lawyers say such ambiguity can add as much as 20% to arbitration costs and delay proceedings, as parties may first have to approach courts to settle jurisdiction before the actual dispute can be heard.

The problem comes amid a sizeable backlog, with about 2.9 lakh arbitration-related cases pending in Indian courts, according to legal-tech and data analytics firm CubicTree.

"Ambiguous clauses leading to a pre-arbitration dispute



About 290,000 cases related to arbitration are pending. AFP

can add at least 20% to the cost of arbitration, as opposed to a watertight, well-drafted clause," said Mumtaz Bhalla, partner at Economic Laws Practice. She said ambiguity over the seat continues to create legal challenges, and that the issue is particularly relevant as ad-hoc arbitration remains common and its clauses are not uniform.

In ad-hoc arbitration, the parties and arbitrators manage

proceedings themselves, without an institution overseeing them. In institutional arbitration, organizations, such as the Singapore International Arbitration Centre (SIAC), International Chamber of Commerce (ICC), or Mumbai Centre for International Arbitration (MCIA), administer the proceedings under their rules.

An arbitration clause is the part of a contract where parties agree to settle certain disputes through arbitration, instead of courts. It usually covers the appointment of arbitrators, the seat, venue and rules of the proceedings. The seat determines which courts supervise the arbitration, while the venue is where hearings are held. The two can be different.

The problem arises when these clauses use standard wording, or boilerplate clauses, without tailored them to the contract, which could

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NEW DELHI

The ministry of heavy industries is considering financial incentives for battery-swappable electric trucks under a proposed ₹9,852 crore programme, according to people familiar with the matter, as the government seeks to address a shortage of charging infrastructure that is slowing the adoption of electric commercial vehicles.

The ministry, the nodal authority for electric vehicles in India, is discussing interest subventions and cheaper financing for electric trucks with swappable batteries, alongside vehicles using conventional charging systems, said a government official, who asked not to be named because the policy is still being finalized. Manufacturers of battery-swappable trucks have been unable to access incen-



Government seeks to address shortage of charging infra. AFP

tives under earlier schemes.

The move comes as Prime Minister Narendra Modi's administration seeks to reduce diesel use in freight transport. Heavy vehicles account for nearly a third of India's diesel usage and over 34% of transport-related carbon emissions, according to Niti Aayog. India had just nine public fast chargers of over 240 kilowatt capacity, underscoring the infrastructure constraints fac-

ing electric trucks.

Mint reported earlier that the ministry was considering interest subventions for charging infrastructure as part of the proposed financing scheme, which aims to put 50,000 electric buses and trucks each on the road over five years. As of May, the scheme was planned with an outlay of ₹9,852 crore.

Government is now also discussing if battery-swapping trucks should be explicitly covered, after manufacturers raised concerns about their eligibility under the existing PME-Drive scheme. The programme has allocated ₹500 crore to incentivize 5,643 electric trucks, along with other vehicle segments and charging infrastructure.

"We are already considering including charging infrastructure in this upcoming financing scheme. Battery-swapping

How billions in Iranian money passes through U.S. banks

Rory Jones & Dylan Tokar

As the Trump administration tightens its economic squeeze on Iran, it faces a surprising weak link in its campaign to cut off the regime from the global financial system: America's own banks.

Billions of dollars of Iranian funds are flowing through clearing accounts at American banks each year, Western officials and researchers say, despite sanctions that prohibit anyone subject to U.S. law from taking part in almost all financial activity linked to Tehran. Iran accesses the accounts through foreign partners that

maintain relationships with U.S. banks, part of a more than century-old system called correspondent banking that helps tie the global financial system together, while also providing Tehran with plenty of ways to secretly infiltrate it.

The Trump administration has recently moved to put foreign banks that process dollar transactions with Iran via U.S. correspondent accounts on alert. Officials have also been pushing American banks to step up their vigilance on Iran-related transactions.

But detecting them can be difficult, since Iran uses a complicated network of front companies and other means to dis-



Illicit Iranian funds are flowing through U.S.-dollar clearing accounts, creating an enforcement dilemma. ISTOCKPHOTO

guise them.

On Aug. 28, the U.S. Treasury identified the Emirati branch of a state-owned Egyptian bank as one of the foreign institutions it believes are helping Iran access the U.S.

banking system, and said it would move to cut it off. Banque Misr's United Arab Emirates branch accessed U.S. correspondent accounts and routed as much as \$1.8 billion for companies that were

potentially part of Iranian shadow-banking networks, officials said.

The Treasury said Misr UAE had U.S. dollar accounts with three U.S. banks but didn't name them. Misr on its website lists JPMorgan Chase and Citigroup as institutions where it has correspondent accounts. Both banks declined to comment on the Treasury action.

Egypt's Foreign Ministry said it was communicating with U.S. authorities about the Treasury's allegations. Misr has said it is engaging with the Treasury and respects "relevant regulatory and legal frameworks." Its Emirati branches are operating normally, the bank said last weekend.

The latest move was part of the Trump administration's

new "Operation Economic Outcast," a wide-ranging pressure campaign aimed at squeezing Iran financially to force concessions and end Middle East hostilities. Washington is warning global leaders to sever ties with Iran or face secondary sanctions—the threat of being cut off from the U.S. dollar financial system entirely.

But some financial experts say Washington's efforts could have limited impact if it doesn't put more pressure on U.S. lenders to scrutinize their correspondent banking relationships more closely. The Treasury last year said it had identified about \$9 billion in Iranian funds that moved

TURN TO PAGE 9

STRAIGHT
FORWARD
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CIVILIZATION?

The newly appointed CEO of the Ram Mandir Trust, air marshal Jeetendra Mishra (ret'd), reached Ayodhya amid media glare to take charge tomorrow. After seeking blessings from the saints, he got down to familiarize himself with the operations and personnel of the trust. We hope air marshal Mishra and his team quickly assume charge at an auspicious time. The team faces insurmountable challenges, but great resets are always preceded by greater hurdles.

You may recall Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath's struggle for beautification of Ayodhya city. Many houses had to be demolished. The marathon exercise finally succeeded, and today the Uttar Pradesh government proudly claims to be the number one state in religious tourism. The shimmering success, however, suffered a dent when the donation theft at the Ram temple was unearthed. We hope air marshal Mishra will be able to firewall devotees' faith from every side.

However, the real test for the team will be to establish the Ram Mandir's ancient glory.

In 2003, the Archaeological Survey of India, under the orders of the Allahabad High Court, excavated the present temple site to ascertain if a temple ever existed. They found clinching evidence, a 12th century Vishnu Hari inscription. It says: At the holy site of Ram's birth place in Saket (Ayodhya) stands a grand temple dedicated to Vishnu Hari. The temple administration has established an *amtsatra* (community feeding centre) for visitors, guests, saints and travellers. Let me mention here that many historians including Irfan Habib challenged the finding, alleging the inscription was taken from the Government Museum in Lucknow and planted at the site as evidence. The allegation fell flat in the Supreme Court and we all know the final result.

The Skanda Purana and the 7th century Chinese traveller Huen Tsang's accounts also support the claims of the inscription. These accounts not only establish the legitimacy of the Ram temple's existence, but point to the attributes that make Ayodhya an abode of virtue. Kashi and Mathura have their unique qualities, too.

Mathura was part of the old Silk Route. Kushan period inscriptions tell us that the treasury at the Krishna Janmasthan temple acted as a bank. Traders would deposit money or seek loan for tough trade journeys.

The grandeur of Kashi was absolutely unique. The reason was that no new idea would be universally accepted till it was debated and proved in the Kashi Vishwanath temple's 'intellectual committee'. Whether it was Shankaracharya or Ramanujacharya, every philosopher had to present, debate and prove their hypothesis.

The city of Vishwanath was also a great centre for astronomy, astrology, logic and medicine. Granary in the Ma Annapoorna temple situated close to Kashi Vishwanath ensured no one in Kashi city would sleep hungry.

Ayodhya was the symbol of the king's conduct and international cooperation and was considered a centre of good governance. Mathura was the centre of commercial banking, sculpting, agriculture and economics even before the advent of Christ. Kashi was the seat of learning, Ayurveda and yoga. Temples like these have helped bring sophistication to our civilization and created a foundation to make it global. Temples in the south were making the same contribution towards our civilization.

You may be wondering how this glorious tradition vanished. We get away by offering a lazy argument putting the entire blame on foreign conquerors. During the foreign rule, security concerns forced India's religious places in the hands of a chosen few. These people promoted narrow vision. This was the beginning of the decline of a great tradition.

A question arises: is the issue limited to just the temple's grandeur and its duties and rights? The inscriptions suggest all the three cities weren't known just for the temples, but for the entire culture and civilisation that these temples spawned. All the three holy cities were a confluence of various strands of culture and civilisations and cooperation in application of knowledge.

Indian intellectual traditions stress on balanced life and as such along with temples they insist on following four stages in life including *dharma* (duty) *artha* (earning a living), *kama* (desire) and *moksha* (liberation). Temples provided a framework and lent strength to *dharma*, *artha* and *moksha*.

Will air marshal Mishra and his colleagues help revive this glorious tradition?

Shashi Shekhar is editor-in-chief, Hindustan. Views are personal.

India working on policy to
support ageing population

BIS tasked with developing framework to push greater workforce participation by the elderly

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NEW DELHI

India's department of consumer affairs is working on a national framework for the country's elderly population that seeks to promote their greater participation in the workforce, ensure good-quality care, support employees with caregiving responsibilities, and create dementia-inclusive communities, among other measures, according to two officials close to the matter.

The plan comes amid concerns over changing family structures and the growing prevalence of nuclear families, as India undergoes a rapid demographic transition. The number of people aged 60 years and above is projected to rise from 100 million in 2011 to 230 million by 2036, increasing their share of the population from 8.4% to 14.9%, according to federal policy think tank Niti Aayog.

The United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA) has projected an even larger long-term shift, estimating that 346 million Indians, nearly 21% of the population, could be aged 60 or above by 2050.

Around half of male senior citizens and 22% of female senior citizens are working, highlighting the significant role older people already play in the country's workforce, according to NITI Aayog's 2024 Senior Care



The plan comes amid concerns over changing family structures and the growing prevalence of nuclear families.

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Reforms paper, which cites the Longitudinal Ageing Study in India (LASI). The latest LASI data, published on 26 February 2024, covered the 2017-18 survey period.

Non-profit organization HelpAge India's 2026 research found that older people living alone often have limited care support: 38% depended on neighbours for care, 20% relied on family members living elsewhere, while 16% received no care at all.

Niti Aayog has identified the implications of demographic ageing for employment, social security, healthcare and the wider economy, and proposed a

national policy for caregivers. Queries emailed to the consumer affairs ministry and HelpAge India chief executive Rohit Prasad remained unanswered.

The Bureau of Indian Standards, which works under the department of consumer affairs, has been tasked with developing the framework, which will have a set of protocols for the quality of care for older persons and their participation in the workforce, said the government officials.

"The government is working on a draft on creating an age-inclusive workforce, with general requirements and guidelines for organizations to address

the needs of an ageing workforce. The proposed guidelines seek to help organizations create an environment that enables older people to continue participating in the workforce," said one of the two officials cited above on condition of anonymity.

"The idea is to help organizations create a work environment that is inclusive of people across different age groups and is responsive to the needs of an ageing workforce," the official said.

India has 705 government-supported senior citizen homes, along with other institutional and home-based elder-care services, according to minister of state for social justice and empowerment B.L. Verma's written reply in the Lok Sabha on 3 February.

"The government will follow international practices and adopt the global framework, which recognizes that care for older people extends beyond institutional facilities to services delivered at home," the second official said, also requesting anonymity.

The move comes as India explores ways to help older people remain economically active and healthy. On 22 July, Union minister for social justice and empowerment Virendra Kumar told the Rajya Sabha that the National Career Service portal had identified 168,000 vacancies as suitable for candidates aged above 60 years.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

'World map
must depict
J-K, Ladakh
accurately'PTI
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NEW DELHI

India on Sunday said a United Nations (UN)-initiated proposed world map must depict the Union territories of Jammu & Kashmir (J&K) and Ladakh in accordance with the country's official map, and any "inaccurate" or "misleading" representation will be unacceptable.

New Delhi's assertion came two days after it voted in favour of a UN General Assembly resolution aimed at correcting the world map to promote a more accurate representation of continental landmasses.

The resolution titled "Correct the Map: Rebalancing Global Cartographic Representation and Promoting Equitable Representation of the World's Regions, Particularly Africa" was adopted on Friday.

External affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said India highlighted that the resolution does not constitute endorsement of any specific map, projection or depiction of national boundaries.

"India voted in favour of the resolution and also made an explanation of vote stressing on the underlying principle of promoting equal-area cartographic representation," he said. Jaiswal was responding to a media query on the issue.

GST Council meet
deferred to 7 OctDhirendra Kumar
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NEW DELHI

The first meeting of the Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council since the rationalization of GST slabs from four to three in September 2025 will now be held on 7 October, instead of 12 September, according to a senior government official.

The 57th meeting of the GST Council is expected to provide an opportunity to review the implementation of the rate rationalization and consider outstanding issues under the indirect tax regime.

There is no change to the venue; the meeting will continue to be held in New Delhi, while the agenda is still being finalized. However, the official did not disclose the reasons for the postponement.

The preparatory meetings of government officers will now be held on 5 October from 3pm

and on 6 October from 11am onwards, ahead of the Council meeting on 7 October, according to an office memorandum sent to council members.

To be sure, India is set to host the 18th BRICS Leaders' Summit in New Delhi on 12-13 September.

Mint's queries emailed to the finance ministry on Sunday remained unanswered.

The 57th meeting will be the first since the Centre and

states approved a major rationalization of the indirect tax regime at the 3 September 2025 meeting. The overhaul simplified the rate structure, with most goods and services moving

into the 5% or 18% slabs, while a 40% rate was retained for select demerit and luxury items. There were four main rate slabs of 5%, 12%, 18% and 28% before.

The revised rates came into effect on 22 September 2025.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

The GST Council meeting will be the first since the rationalization of the tax regime at the 3 September 2025 meeting

India's InvITs target ₹20 trillion assets

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India's infrastructure investment trusts (InvITs) will soon no longer be only about roads and telecom.

Targeting more than ₹20 trillion in assets by 2030, they are set for a sharp expansion with power, shipping, logistics, data centres, ports and railways emerging as the next big pool of assets, according to N.S. Venkatesh, chief executive officer (CEO) of the Bharat InvITs Association, an industry lobby group.

The near-tripling of the current asset base of about ₹7.3 trillion will be driven by a growing pipeline of operational infrastructure assets and the need among developers and governments to recycle capital into new projects, Venkatesh said in an interview. The expansion will mark a significant evolution for a market that has so far been dominated by roads and telecom.

Roads and highways currently account for about 40% of the InvIT asset base, but their share could fall to 30-35% as newer sectors enter the market.

"Every year, you will actu-



Power, shipping, logistics, data centres, ports and railways are emerging as the next big pool of assets, says N.S. Venkatesh.

ally see at least one sector getting added," Venkatesh said.

The shift reflects a broader change in the way infrastructure assets are financed in India.

InvITs allow developers to transfer operational, cash-generating assets into a separate investment vehicle, unlock capital and deploy the proceeds into fresh projects. For investors, the model provides access to mature infrastructure assets with relatively

The expansion will mark a significant evolution for a market so far dominated by roads, telecom

predictable cash flows. The distinction between operational and greenfield assets is particularly important. New infrastructure projects carry risks related to land acquisition, right of way, approvals and construction. Operational assets have an established revenue history that

make them more suitable for an investment structure designed to provide regular distributions to investors.

predictable cash flows.

The distinction between operational and greenfield assets is particularly important.

New infrastructure projects carry risks related to land acquisition, right of way, approvals and construction. Operational assets have an established revenue history that

make them more suitable for an investment structure designed to provide regular distributions to investors.

Power transmission and generation could become important additions to the InvIT universe, while warehouses, logistics parks and data centres are emerging as potential asset classes, Venkatesh said. The rapid growth of digital infrastructure and the need for energy-storage capacity could further widen the pipeline, he added.

Shipping presents another potentially large opportunity. Ships are capable of generating identifiable revenue and could, subject to the appropriate structure, be owned through an InvIT, while a separate operator deploys them for cargo or passenger movement. Revenue from operations could then support distributions to investors. The Bharat InvIT Association is working on standardized frameworks for such structures, Venkatesh said.

Ports could be monetized, particularly through operational terminals rather than entire port assets. Warehouses and logistics facilities could be pooled once they become operational and generate stable cash flows.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Govt may block new nicotine pouch formulations amid addiction risks

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The National Tobacco Control Programme (NTCP) has recommended that India's top drug advisory body reject licence applications for manufacturing, importing and marketing new nicotine pouch formulations in 2mg, 4mg and 6mg strengths, citing concerns that the small, tobacco-free, flavoured sachets could undermine efforts to curb nicotine use and protect public health, according to two government officials and a government

document reviewed by Mint.

The applications before India's top drug advisory body, the Drugs Technical Advisory Board (DTAB), are for pouches containing different forms of nicotine, intended for smoking cessation and relief from withdrawal symptoms, amid concerns that they could encourage nicotine initiation and long-term addiction. The sachets are placed between the gum and lip to release nicotine and have gained popularity among young people.

According to the document, various applications were received by the India's apex drug controller—the Central



The NTCP has cited concerns that the tobacco-free flavoured sachets could undermine efforts to curb nicotine use.

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Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO)—for grant of manufacturing/import and marketing of nicotine pouches

in 2mg, 4mg and 6mg strengths containing different salts of nicotine such as nicotine ditartrate dihydrate, nicot-

ine polacrilex, etc. for smoking cessation.

"... TCD (Tobacco Control Division, under the health ministry) has emphasized that evidence-based cessation methods should be prioritized over nicotine pouches and recommended refraining from granting licenses for new nicotine formulations," the document stated.

Nicotine pouches contain no tobacco leaf and are marketed as "tobacco-free", "modern" and "safer alternatives" to conventional tobacco products. They deliver nicotine through the gums without smoking or vaping and are

promoted for smoking cessation and withdrawal relief. Flavoured variants, sleek packaging, influencer campaigns and aggressive digital marketing have raised concerns over their appeal to young people, much as with e-cigarettes.

The Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), under the health ministry, had asked the Drugs Controller General of India (DCGI) to ensure that all applications related to tobacco products or nicotine substances were discussed with the NTCP.

Subsequently, CDSCO informed DGHS and NTCP about the details of application

for manufacturing, marketing and import and nicotine cases for the indication of smoking cessation and sought opinion on the same.

In response, NTCP and health ministry wrote to the CDSCO stating that "these nicotine pouches are addictive, carry independent health risks, and are not effective cessation aids."

Queries sent to the health ministry, DGHS, DCGI and nicotine pouches sellers Velo, Pouched India and ZeroSmoke on Saturday remained unanswered till press time.

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AI ads are catching up and the industry is taking note

Across regional markets, AI adoption is fastest where cultural, language diversity is highest

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NEW DELHI

With AI becoming a common part of the creative process in advertising, brands and content makers assessing its effectiveness against non-AI content have a reason to cheer. According to data from global advertising technology platform VDO.AI, on connected TV, AI-generated ads recorded a 92% video completion rate (VCR), slightly higher than the 90% seen for non-AI creatives. A similar trend appeared in online video, where AI-led ads achieved a 71% VCR compared to 70% for non-AI ads.

Industry executives say AI-guided creative assets can match the effectiveness of traditional human-made spots, provided the message is clear, the format fits and the audience targeting is on point.

Across regional markets, adoption is moving fastest where cultural and language diversity is highest. Historically, India's multi-language landscape created major production bottlenecks for national campaigns. Now, dynamic creative tools let agencies translate and adapt creative hooks, voiceovers and contextual details into regional languages at once.

"Advertising in India has evolved alongside changing consumer behaviour, and today that evolution is being shaped by data and AI. Across the



On connected TV, AI-generated ads recorded a 92% video completion rate. ISTOCKPHOTO

advertising value chain, AI is helping advertisers derive audience insights, optimize media planning, personalize campaigns, and enhance measurement," said Anil Goel, global chief tech-

On the creative side, brands are using generative AI to produce multiple versions of ad copies, images and videos, significantly reducing production timelines and enabling rapid test-

AI BOOST

GENERATIVE AI helps significantly reducing production timelines, enabling rapid testing

BRANDS are tapping live data feeds to tweak ad visuals and text at the time of delivery

HYUNDAI paired live AI data with custom messaging for the Creta EV on connected screens

DYNAMIC creative tools localize hooks and voiceovers across languages instantly

nology officer at Nielsen.

As adoption grows, the focus is shifting from automation alone to improving relevance, transparency and decision-making, Goel added.

ing. In media, AI powers bidding strategies, audience segmentation, predictive targeting and budget allocation across platforms like Google, Meta and programmatic ecosystems.

Vishal Agrahari, vice-president, paid media at BC Web Wise, said AI is also helping brands localize campaigns into multiple Indian languages at scale, something that was previously time-consuming and expensive.

Language localization is one of AI's biggest strengths in India, but adoption is uneven across industries.

According to Rajiv Dingra, founder and chief executive officer, ReBid, digital-first businesses such as e-commerce, fintech, gaming and D2C brands have embraced AI much faster because they already operate on rapid experimentation cycles. More regulated sectors such as banking, insurance and healthcare are adopting AI more cautiously, with stronger human review processes.

Amita Madhvani, producer and co-owner of Equinox Films and Ram Madhvani Films, sees AI as an important part of advertising in India, but more as an enabler than a replacement for creativity.

One of the most interesting shifts is dynamic, context-aware advertising. Brands are tapping live data feeds to tweak ad visuals and text at the moment of delivery. For instance, Hyundai paired live AI data with custom messaging for the Creta EV on connected digital screens, making sure its sustainability pitch felt immediate and locally relevant, Preetesh Chouhan, co-founder and chief technology officer at Vibetheory.AI, pointed out.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

Private credit secondaries gain ground on return clarity

Mansi Verma & Priyamvada C
MUMBAI

India's private-credit market is seeing growing demand for something it does not yet have at scale: a true secondary market.

Investors are increasingly looking beyond fresh fund commitments to seasoned credit assets, where repayment history, borrower performance and expected cash flows are already visible, but most transactions in India today are refinancings or early sell-downs, rather than the investor-to-investor portfolio trades typical of mature credit-secondary markets, industry participants told *Mint*.

That could change as more private-credit managers build multiple fund vintages and earlier funds approach maturity, creating a larger pool of established assets for investors to buy.

The appeal is greater visibility into risk. Investors can assess how a borrower has performed since the original investment, whether leverage has fallen and whether the business has survived a period of volatility.

"We are seeing a lot of opportunities for takeouts," said Aakash Desai, chief investment officer and head of Private Credit, 360 ONE Asset. "Today, compared to two years ago, the amount of refinancing has increased. That's a function of more confidence



In developed markets, private-credit secondaries typically involve an existing investor selling its exposure to another investor. MINT

in the market and more capital flows, and an increased amount of diligence on underlying credits."

Desai said global investors are also enquiring about established Indian credit exposures.

Others such as Axis and ICICI Prudential have also moved into successive funds

while their earlier vintages mature, giving investors greater visibility into underlying assets and realised returns.

The global market illustrates the potential.

Earlier this year, Ares Management raised \$7.1 billion for its debut Ares Credit Secondaries Fund, one of the largest dedicated institutional credit-secondary funds globally.

Collier Capital's dedicated credit-secondary fund had exposure to about 1,660 portfolio companies across 34 managers as of March 2026.

India, however, remains at an earlier stage.

In developed markets, private-credit secondaries typically involve an existing investor selling its exposure to another investor, often to meet liquidity needs, rebalance a portfolio or exit as a fund approaches maturity.

That is not yet the norm in India, said Vishal Bansal, partner at EY. Much of what is described as secondary activity instead involves an investor selling down shortly after the original transaction or a borrower refinancing existing debt.

Globally, the market is much more developed.

Evercore's 2025 Credit Secondary Market Survey, published in January, said global credit-secondary volumes nearly doubled to \$20 billion in 2025.

India could eventually follow that path as more funds mature.

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RPG bets on China-plus-one, goes on an API buying spree

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RPG Life Sciences has spent ₹215 crore buying two active pharmaceutical ingredient (API) makers in the space of five weeks—an aggressive run for a company owned by a group known for watching every rupee of capital. And it is not done. The drugmaker has a further ₹700 crore earmarked for inorganic growth, and is already hunting larger targets.

Driving the spree is a bet on how the world buys its medicines now. "The conversations are not around India versus China," managing director Ashok Nair told *Mint*. "China continues to be a part of the global pharma supply." What has changed is that customers want sourcing diversification and reduced concentration—the essence of the 'China plus one' strategy—and 'India is well positioned to benefit from this trend', helped by government incentives, he said.

RPG is a trusted supplier for some APIs, but by integrating backwards into key ingredients, it hopes to ink long-term contracts.

That is the gauntlet RPG has picked up. Under a group whose leadership, in Nair's telling, "continuously keeps reviewing costs and capital costs," the ₹707-crore company has swung from caution to conviction, backing capacity in a business most large Indian drugmakers quietly run but rarely talk up.

"We have grown from ₹200 crore to ₹700 crore in the last five years," Nair said. "What we are looking at is how we move to ₹1,000 crore soon." Inorganic growth was always on the cards, he added, but the pace has quickened since he took charge 14 months ago. "The speed has increased, and the sense of urgency. Our appetite is more."

G Active Pharma (RPGAP), into which RPG carved out its API operations in late July, brought in healthcare PE firm InvAscent, which is investing ₹243 crore for a 40% stake, with the partners committing up to ₹700 crore, largely for acquisitions. The company moved fast. RPGAP agreed to buy Visakhapatnam-based



RPG is a trusted supplier for APIs, but by integrating backwards into key ingredients, it hopes to ink long-term contracts. BLOOMBERG

Actis Generics, a maker of intermediates and key starting materials, for ₹80 crore. Five weeks later, it signed a pact to acquire the API and intermediates business of Raghava Life Sciences for ₹135 crore, adding an EU-GMP- and WHO-GMP-approved plant near Hyderabad and 29 molecules. The two deals lifted RPGAP's capacity nearly fivefold, from about 110 kilolitres to roughly 505 kl.

They also fit together. Actis supplies intermediates for complex molecules such as rivaroxaban and apixaban; Raghava makes the finished APIs. "We have gone down that path, and that's where all the value is," Nair described a deliberate move to integrate backwards down the chemistry chain rather than simply add tonnage.

His case rests on the economics of APIs, which he argues are far less crowded than finished formulations. "API continues to be a play where it is niche and super-special," he said, citing rivaroxaban, whose synthesis runs to 17 steps. "There are very few organisations [that] can do it—a barrier that limits competition and props up prices in a way the first-to-file scramble in formulations does not. Nair pegs the Indian API market at 'upwards of ₹1 trillion', growing about 8% a year. India is the third-largest producer—a pool the Centre's production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme is helping the country capture.

Brokerages are buying the story. ICICI Securities rates the stock Buy with a 12-month

target of ₹3,205—roughly 20% above the current price—at 34 times projected FY28 earnings. In a 4 September note, lead analyst Siddhant Khandekar wrote the deals position APIs as 'a key medium-term growth driver, with a potential for further value unlocking'.

Khandekar was blunt about what comes next: "We expect more deals in the API space." Khandekar reckons Raghava's plant, which earned about ₹19 crore last year, could support close to ₹200 crore at full utilisation, though he flagged the 'delay in integration of new API businesses' as a key risk—the two units brought in only about ₹70 crore last year.

The acquisitions expand its capabilities, with the ramp-up expected over the next 18 months. RPG's move matters less for its size—₹215 crore is small by pharma M&A standards—than for who is making it. If a mid-sized, capital-conservative player sees enough in China-plus-one to build a dedicated, PE-funded acquisition platform, the thesis has broadened well beyond the big generic houses.

The heavyweights are in: Hyderabad-based Aurobindo Pharma, through a subsidiary, ploughed upwards of ₹2,500 crore into a Penicillin G plant at Kakinada under PLI—chasing a market India had all but ceded to China, which supplied a bulk of the over ₹2,000 crore of Penicillin G the country imported in FY24.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Traders turn bullish on China's AI alternative

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Investors seeking to diversify beyond crowded AI trades in Korea and Japan are increasingly seizing on Chinese equity derivatives.

Trading desks from Barclays Plc to UBS Group AG are seeing rising client demand for bullish options and swap contracts tied to China's CSI indexes in recent weeks. Meanwhile, more strategists are recommending derivative

trades to position for gains, particularly in the mid- and small-cap space.

Key drivers for Chinese stocks include ongoing capital market reforms that support a gradual bull market, advances in self-reliant technology and an improving earnings outlook across hardware sectors, according to BNP Paribas SA and Bank of America Corp. In a recent report, UBS highlighted the CSI 500 as an alternative artificial intelligence bet for investors

looking to diversify their exposure.

Yet even as optimism creeps back in, traders remain cautious about the nation's economic outlook and government support. The CSI 1000 Index, up after posting its worst monthly loss since 2016 in July, is still 16% below its high in May. Meanwhile, implied volatility—the gauge of options prices—has slumped back toward its one-year average, making derivative bets more appealing.

"It's an ideal trade now because people are a bit on edge," said Lars Naekter, head of Asia Pacific equity derivatives research at Bank of America. He recommends call spreads on the CSI 1000. "Rather than piling into cash equities or futures, options make sense, especially when pricing is in your favor. At some point, a catalyst will emerge, and it is often cheaper to be tactically proactive ahead of a move rather than reactive."

At Barclays, the desk is seeing rising client interest in call spreads on onshore indexes, with many positioning for a gradual climb rather than a sharp rally. Outperformance trades linked to the CSI 300 and CSI 500 indexes are also compelling versus recent history, according to Kaanhari Singh, the bank's head of Asia Pacific equity-flow derivatives sales. "We've seen growing investor interest in China A-share upside strategies in recent months," Singh said. "

MINT MEDIA MARKETING INITIATIVE

Understanding expense ratios and other costs in mutual funds

When investors evaluate mutual funds, they often focus on returns and overlook an equally important aspect, costs. Every investment comes with certain expenses, and understanding these costs helps investors make more informed decisions. One of the most commonly discussed costs in mutual funds is the expense ratio. While costs matter, they should always be viewed in the context of the value investors receive through professional management, research, operations, and investor services.

An expense ratio represents the annual cost charged for managing and operating a mutual fund scheme. These expenses may include fund management fees, administrative costs, registrar services, investors education, investors communication and distribution-related expenses where applicable. The expense ratio is expressed as a percentage of the fund's average assets under management and is reflected in the scheme's Net

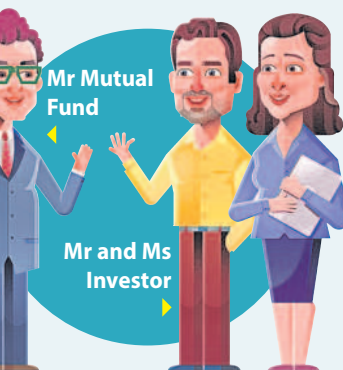
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Asset Value (NAV).

Simply put, investors do not pay this amount separately, it is adjusted against the NAV (expenses deducted from the market value of the investments before calculating the per unit value).

Ms Investor: I saw two similar mutual funds, but one had a lower expense ratio. Should I always choose the cheaper one?

Mr Mutual Fund: Not necessarily. Cost is important, but it should not



Suppose Investor A and Investor B both invest ₹1 lakh in two similar funds. One fund has a lower expense ratio and the other slightly higher. Over time, what matters is whether the overall experience, including the investment strategy, fund manager expertise and other aspects, align with the investor's goals.

Apart from expense ratio, investors may come across other costs associated with mutual fund investing. Check the table given below.

Cost Component	What It Means	What Investors Should Know
Expense Ratio	Annual cost of managing the scheme	Adjusted within NAV
Exit Load	Charge applicable on redemption within specified period	Encourages longer-term investing

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.
Disclaimer: Know Your Customer (KYC) is mandatory to complete KYC process before investing in Mutual Funds (MF). For this, submit the completed KYC Form at any Asset Management Company (AMC) branch or nearest Point of Service (POS) or through a financial advisor. For KYC Form, click here: <https://www.canararobeco.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/02/cr-central-kyc-registry-application-form-individual.pdf>. If you would like to update any KYC information (address, contact details etc.), submit the KYC Form with updated details at your nearest AMC branch or POS. Check KYC status at Know Your Status (www.kyc.kyc.com). For change of bank details registered with any MF, download bank mandate change form from that MF's website, and submit the form to that MF's branches or Official Points of Acceptance. SEBI Registered Mutual Funds: Investors should deal only with registered Mutual Funds, details of which can be verified on the SEBI website under 'Investment/Market Infrastructure Institutions' at <https://www.sebi.gov.in/investments/Market-Infrastructure-Institutions>. For complaints, contact the Investor Service Department of the respective MF. For contact details, refer scheme related documents of MFs. In case, the investor is not satisfied with the resolution, the investor can complain on SCORES platform (SEBI Complaints Redress System) at <https://scores.sebi.gov.in>. For cases, where the investor is not satisfied with the resolution by AMC/MF or through SCORES, the investor can complain on Online Dispute Resolution Portal ('ODRP Portal') at <https://smar.tomorrows.in/login>. This material is a part of the Investor Education and Awareness Initiative by Canara Robeco Mutual Fund. ● SEBI Registered Name: Canara Robeco Mutual Fund ● SEBI Registration Number: MF/004/93/4

Mr Investor: I've heard people say that lower expense ratio automatically means higher returns. Is that true?

Mr Mutual Fund: Not always. Costs matter, but they are only one part of the investment decision. Choosing solely on cost is like choosing a doctor only because the consultation fee is lower, you should also consider expertise, suitability and other factors.

Mr Investor: Then what should I focus on while selecting a mutual fund?

Mr Mutual Fund: Start with your goals, investment horizon, and risk comfort. Then understand the fund category and costs together, not independently.

Understanding expense ratios and related costs helps investors move beyond headline numbers and make more balanced decisions. The objective is not to find the cheapest option, but to understand what you are paying for and whether it supports your long-term financial goals.

S&P BSE Sensex	Nifty 50	Nifty 500	Nifty Next 50	Nifty 100	S&P BSE Mid-cap	S&P BSE Small Cap
CLOSE 76515.43	CLOSE 23897.70	CLOSE 23254.15	CLOSE 72880.90	CLOSE 25023.15	CLOSE 17097.94	CLOSE 7281.80
1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -0.97	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -1.15	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -1.17	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -1.72	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -1.26	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) 1.37	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) 0.03
1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -2.44	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -2.91	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -1.84	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -1.79	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -2.71	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -0.29	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) 1.54
3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 2.90	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 2.05	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 3.36	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 4.10	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 2.44	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 4.90	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 7.31
6-MONTH CHANGE (%) -3.29	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) -2.38	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) 3.77	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) 9.10	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) -0.38	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) 11.09	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) 20.67
1-YEAR CHANGE (%) -5.21	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) -3.38	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) 1.90	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) 8.53	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) -1.31	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) 7.95	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) 7.77



The IPOs are scheduled to hit the market between 7 September and 15 September. ISTOCKPHOTO

Eleven firms to raise ₹7,055 cr in IPO rush

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The primary market is poised for another action-packed week, with 11 main-board companies, including Rentomojo, Karamtara Engineering and Kanohar Electricals, set to raise ₹7,055 crore through initial public offerings (IPOs). The IPOs are scheduled to hit the market between 7 September and 15 September, with most of the issues opening for subscription on Tuesday and Wednesday.

"This multi-issue rush reflects an eagerness to lock in early-stage growth equity in young companies as all these companies are below \$1 billion market cap at listing," Raj Kumar Rath, chief investment officer at YES Securities, said.

The companies tapping the primary market include real estate developers, engineering and manufacturing firms, a payments and identity solutions provider, a specialty chemicals manufacturer and an online retail platform.

Of ₹7,055 crore, ₹2,722 crore (39%) is primary capital issuance, where funds go into the company, and ₹4,333 crore (61%) is a secondary sale by existing shareholders. This mobilisation highlights strong corporate confidence and

robust liquidity available within the Indian primary market, Rath said.

The funds raised through the fresh issues will largely be utilised for business expansion, capital expenditure, debt repayment, working capital requirements and other general corporate purposes.

The upcoming IPO rush follows a busy start to September, with Rays of Belief and Deepa Jewellers already launching their IPOs on 1 September. With these issues, the number of companies launching IPOs in 2026 is expected to rise to 75. This includes 23 issues launched in August.

Companies tapping the primary market include real estate developers, among others

Against this backdrop, Pranav Constructions will be the first among the 11 companies to open its IPO for public subscription on 7 September. The over ₹351-crore issue will close on September 9. This will be followed by Kanohar Electricals, Prasol Chemicals and Glass Wall Systems (India), which will open their IPOs on 8 September. Rentomojo, Mani Payment and Identity Solutions, Arcil, LCC Projects, Karamtara Engineering and Steamhouse India will launch their issues on 9 September, while Veegland Developers will open its IPO on 10 September. Pranav Constructions has fixed a price band of ₹118-124 per share for its IPO.

CAS fear grips BSE investors

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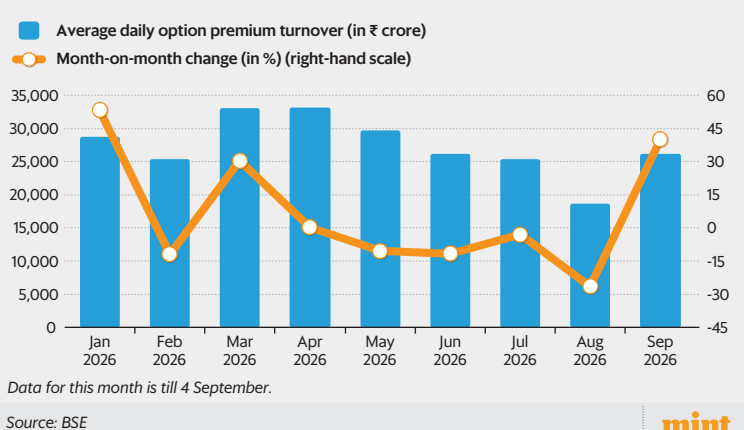
The BSE stock has gained nearly 8% in the last two trading sessions on hopes of Sebi's review of the closing auction session (CAS). CAS was introduced from 3 August for closing price discovery and replaced the earlier method of volume weighted average price (VWAP). This led to extreme price swings, resulting in dwindling derivatives (F&O) volumes.

While Sebi has noted the concerns of the trading community, it is unlikely that it will revert to VWAP. This is because CAS was introduced to remove the drawback of VWAP, wherein large traders, institutional or non-institutional, with deep pockets were able to influence the closing price by manipulating prices of stocks having significant weightage in the index.

Secondly, CAS has not led to wild price swings in the cash market. Even in derivatives, volatility is more pronounced in the BSE Sensex than in the Nifty 50, as the BSE Sensex has been comparatively less liquid.

Sign of revival?

BSE's average daily option premium turnover got a CAS shock in August, but September's early trend is encouraging.



Post CAS, the average daily option premium turnover on BSE dropped 26% month-on-month in August to ₹18,672 crore, compared with a 16% fall on the National Stock Exchange (NSE) to ₹42,332 crore.

Why is average daily option premium turnover crucial? Well, transaction charges are BSE's largest revenue stream, contributing nearly 78% in the

June quarter (QIFY27). Within transaction charges, options contribute as much as 95%, with the remaining coming from the cash segment. BSE does not charge for transactions in the futures segment.

So, if CAS is likely to stay with some modifications, particularly regarding the 3% price band, should BSE's investors lose hope of a revival in average

daily option premium turnover and, hence, transaction charges income?

Well, there is a glimmer of hope. Market participants, or traders, are getting accustomed to CAS if September's initial trends are anything to go by. BSE's average daily option premium turnover in the first four trading sessions this month has recovered sharply to ₹26,184 crore, or 40% higher than August.

Nonetheless, Q2FY27 transaction charges income could be lower than QIFY27.

As per *Mint* estimates, based on data for July, August and September so far, average daily option premium turnover is likely to be around ₹23,500 crore, or 21% lower QoQ, even as it will be 57% higher year-on-year.

However, more trading days in Q2FY27—65 versus 60 in QIFY27—would limit the drop in derivatives transaction charges to about 14%.

Investors seem to have priced in the short-term pain of lower transaction charges income, as BSE's shares have already lost about 23% of their value

from the 27 May peak of ₹4,446.80.

The average daily option premium turnover peaked in April at ₹33,145 crore, after which it started sliding due to various issues such as higher securities Transaction Tax (STT), changes in bank guarantee norms for proprietary traders and CAS implementation.

The pressure on the stock was further accentuated as investors anticipated the opportunity to buy an alternative exchange play after rival NSE filed its Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) on 17 June.

BSE's price-to-earnings multiple is now at 43, based on FY27 *Bloomberg* consensus estimates.

BSE deserves a higher valuation multiple than other capital market plays, given the duopoly-like

industry structure of stock exchanges. Plus, early indications from September numbers suggest that the bulk of the pain from CAS-related issues is behind it.

That means further downside for the stock could be limited, unless new concerns emerge.

CLOSING GAMES

SEBI has noted the concerns of the trading community, but it is unlikely that it will revert to VWAP

BSE deserves a higher valuation multiple than other capital market plays

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Disputes on arbitration location raise focus on contracts

FROM PAGE 1

lead to disputes and litigation. If the seat, venue and jurisdiction are not clearly mentioned, it can create further confusion.

Abhilek Chaturvedi, partner at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas, said common drafting problems include using "venue" and "place" interchangeably without making the parties' intention clear. Another problem is naming only a venue, without specifying the seat or the courts that will have jurisdiction. Disputes can also arise when an agreement gives exclusive jurisdiction to courts in one city, while the arbitration clause refers to another location.

Law firms say such ambiguities can also lead to seat shopping, where parties seek a favourable court or legal regime. While choosing a seat is legitimate, problems arise when an unclear clause is used to seek a favourable forum after a dispute has started. "Seat-shopping, or forum-shopping is a common dispute strategy, particularly in cross-border contracts and disputes," said Shantee Parikh, partner at Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co.

The seat is crucial as it determines the courts that supervise arbitration and deal with challenges to the award, she said.

Nusrat Hassan, managing partner at Dentons Link Legal, said the choice of seat can determine the supervisory court, procedural law and forum for challenging an award. In India, he said, it can also determine whether a challenge goes before a district or a high court, affecting timelines, appeals and costs.

The issue can also arise in international arbitration, where an unclear seat can create jurisdictional disputes and lead to litigation in another country.

Hassan recalled a case where Indian law governed the contract, Singapore was the venue and SIAC administered the arbitration, but the seat was not clearly specified. Though India appeared to be the intended seat, Singapore was treated as the implied seat, so any challenge to the award had to be filed before Singapore courts, leading to lengthy litigation.

The issue has received fresh attention from courts this year.

In April, the Supreme Court held that the seat is the legal location of arbitration and



Ambiguous drafting is triggering disputes over where arbitration should take place and which courts have jurisdiction. ISTOCKPHOTO

determines which courts will have jurisdiction over the proceedings. Once the seat is fixed,

arbitration, while New Delhi was only the venue. Similarly, in June 2026, in a dispute between Bhartia Infra Projects and Vishwa Samudra Engineering, Supreme Court held that where an arbitration clause mentions two possible seats or venues but gives exclusive jurisdiction to one court, that court will have supervisory jurisdiction. It also held that there was

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no need to consider if another court would be a more convenient forum to hear the case.

Lawyers said such disputes are likely to recur despite courts giving better clarity, particularly when contracts rely on standard wording. "As arbitration volumes grow and contracts get more complex, multi-party, multi-jurisdiction, boilerplate clauses reused across deals lead to a repetition of these issues," said Chaturvedi.

CubicTree's latest dataset, shared with *Mint* by its chief executive and founder Hitesh Jirwala, shows a significant backlog of arbitration-related cases in Indian courts. As of 2 September, 289,525 cases were pending of the total 729,761 in the dataset. Of these, 440,236 cases had been disposed of, giving a disposal rate of 60.3%.

The data shows that delays remain a major concern. 152,649 pending cases were over three years old, including 98,379 cases older than five and 21,494 cases older than 10 years. The median age of a pending case was 40 months, while the average age was 52.2 months.

District and sessions courts accounted for 598,792 cases,

compared with 130,966 cases in high courts. Average time taken to dispose of a case was 21.1 months, while the slowest 10% took 59.1 months or more.

The data also shows a strong role for financial institutions, with 55.2% of cases filed by banks, NBFCs or financiers.

"Arbitration is rising as it is now written into almost everything we sign, which includes vehicle loan, infrastructure contract with a vendor agreement that carries a clause along with a retail credit and arbitration expanded with it," said Jirwala. "Hence, filings have grown 13.5% a year since 2015."

A 2024 Khaitan & Co survey showed while arbitration remains preferred over litigation, only 40% respondents were satisfied with domestic arbitration. About 66% said time limits were not being followed, with most cases taking 24-36 months.

It found that 52% respondents preferred institutional arbitration, while 40% preferred ad-hoc arbitration. Responses to queries emailed on Sunday to the major arbitration centres and to the law and justice ministry, were awaited.

Small-cap corrections narrow to 25% post-covid: SageOne's Vartak

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Small cap stocks used to fall by around 40-45% during corrections in the pre-covid period. However, post-covid, the average decline has been closer to 25%, said Samir Vartak, founder and chief investment officer of SageOne Investment Managers.

Simultaneously, earnings growth has accelerated, Vartak told *Mint* in an interview. While small-cap earnings were growth largely mirrored that of large caps prior to covid, though with greater volatility, it now outpaces large-cap earnings growth by at least 5 to 8 percentage points.

Edited excerpts:
Where do you see pockets of growth now?

Small caps tend to be very cyclical. In the past, they went through a 3-4 year cycle, followed by 9-18 months of correction. The peak was around September 2024, and 18 months later the correction

phase was largely complete. But now the earnings growth is picking up specially in March and June. Small-cap earnings growth was around 32%, while mid-cap was 28%. So, based on the cyclical and earnings trajectory, we are entering a good 2.5 year phase for Smids (small and mid-cap companies).

Your strategy deals mainly in small caps. Why do you prefer small caps to other stocks?

Small caps have become bigger in size. The market cap of the 1,000th company was around ₹240 crore in 2019. Today, it is above ₹3,000 crore, or 13 times larger. In 2019, a ₹23,000 crore company was a large cap. Today, a ₹37,000 crore company is a small cap based on Sebi's definition.

Secondly, the quality of small caps has improved significantly post-covid. In 2019, the median net debt-to-equity ratio for the small-cap universe was around 0.5 to 0.6. Today, it is almost zero. More than 50% of small-cap compa-

nies are debt-free.

Profitability has also improved. Return on equity for the small-cap universe used to be around 10-12%; today, it is about 15%.

The same is true of cash-flow collection. Earlier, companies could show good profits, but a lot of the money was stuck in receivables. Operating cash flow to net profit was around 85-90%. Today, it is around 115-120%.

So, the small-cap companies are now much larger and have increased profitability, high cash flows, and low leverage.

Previously, small caps used to fall around 40-45% during a correction. Post-covid, the average fall has been about 25%. While, earnings growth has picked up. Pre-covid, small-cap earnings growth was broadly similar to that of large caps, albeit more volatile. Today, small-cap earnings growth is at least 5-8% higher than that of large caps.

The opportunity size for a fund manager like me has also increased. Large caps would account for 75% of the total market cap but it has dropped to about 58%. So the opportu-



nity size has gone up. **Within small caps, where is the growth coming from?**

Financials, FMCG, IT, and oil marketing companies account for nearly 70% of the total Nifty weight.

Small caps have very little exposure to financial services, IT or FMCG. Most are manufacturing-oriented—building materials, power ancillaries, power companies, defence, CDMO (contract development and manufacturing organization) and other critical industries. That is

where the real growth is happening.

There is also a lot of export-oriented growth. With FTAs (free trade agreements) being signed with the UK and Europe, we are seeing opportunities in textiles and garments, CDMOs and specialty chemicals. The rupee's depreciation is also helping So, with bottom-up stock picking, you will mostly find good, export-oriented companies.

Taiwan and South Korea are now seeing meaningful foreign outflows, yet India

has not seen a corresponding large-scale shift in capital. So, is the 'India as an anti-AI trade' thesis actually playing out?

The biggest risk today is the rise in interest rates in the US and globally. The US 30-year yield is almost 5.3%, the highest since 2007-08. The 10-year yield has also crossed 4.8%. Whenever interest rates go up, emerging markets are generally perceived riskier. So there is some outflow from emerging markets, and India is part of that basket.

South Korea and Taiwan are also very much AI trades. When interest rates go up, the AI trade becomes less attractive because it requires a lot of investment. Higher interest costs make that capital more expensive and reduce the return on investment.

Valuations are another factor. PE multiples are widely followed, but for cyclical busi-

Based on the cyclical and earnings trajectory, we are entering a good 2.5 year phase for Smids

Samir Vartak
Founder of SageOne Investment Managers

nesses like chips, price-to-book is a better measure. SK Hynix, for example, used to trade at around 1 to 1.5 times book value and recently went up to almost 10-11 times. Samsung went from around 1 to 1.5 times, to 5 to 6 times book value. When valuations become expensive, they start trimming positions.

So there are three things happening: emerging markets are becoming less attractive; the AI trade is becoming less attractive because of higher interest rates; and valuations in markets such as South Korea and Taiwan have become expensive.

For India, allocation will always be driven by growth. Investors will come when India's growth is significantly better than the rest of the world. Today, India doesn't offer a great growth differential. US companies are growing at similar rates, while compa-

nies like Samsung, SK Hynix, and certain Taiwanese companies are growing much faster. India's growth is in rupee terms, so if rupee is depreciating, dollar growth is even lower.

Is the defence theme coming back?

There is huge capex happening in defence and the demand has probably gone up six- or seven-fold in the past three years.

Now, India is focusing on becoming an export hub for defence. That is why Indian companies, particularly those involved in rockets, missiles and ammunition, are doing exceedingly well. They are getting huge orders from multiple countries.

What about valuations, though?

In large caps, companies like Solar Industries, Data Patterns and others are trading at very high multiples—around 50-80x. But once you move to the small-cap space, there are many defence companies available at around 20-25 times earnings.

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Edelweiss charts a 25-year path to build, unlock value

Chair Rashesh Shah's 'investment house' model sits between a PE fund and a holding company

Shayan Ghosh & Sneha Shah
MUMBAI

The Edelweiss group sees itself as an investment house and incubator of long-term financial services businesses, and has identified a few white spaces it aims to fill, said co-founder and chairman Rashesh Shah.

Edelweiss Financial Services Ltd, the holding company, is listed and valued at about ₹12,873 crore. It has seven subsidiaries: an alternatives company, an asset management company, a non-bank financier, a mortgage lender, and general and life insurance companies.

"We are not a private equity (PE) firm which takes a three- to five-year view. We are not a holding company that takes a 100-year view and keeps control in the family. We want to incubate, build, and grow businesses, but over 25 years," said Shah, seated on the 15th floor of the company's headquarters.

Shah likes to call Edelweiss an "investment house" and said it is somewhere between a holding company and a PE firm. "We don't want to hold it (subsidiaries) forever; once the business has grown, value is created, you unlock the value."

Shah said the group is incubating some other new businesses and these are expected to be announced in March 2027.

He did not want to disclose what these businesses are. Broadly, he said that since artificial intelligence (AI) has entered the market, there are newer white spaces available.

He said there are opportunities in aiding rich Indians investing abroad as many high-net-worth investors want to invest through GIFT City.

As proof of the group's track record in incubating and then offloading investments, Shah cited the case of Nuvama Wealth Management, which got listed in 2023, where Edelweiss



(L-R) Rashesh Shah, co-founder and chairman of the Edelweiss group, and Amit Agarwal, CEO of EAAA India Alternatives.

shareholders received 30% of the shares. Earlier in 2021, Singapore-based alternative investment manager PAG bought a majority stake in Nuvama and is the current promoter of the firm.

Interestingly, Nuvama's market cap at ₹33,448 crore, is now almost thrice that of Edelweiss. Shah said he is happy



business that has a fee-paying assets under management of ₹48,623 crore. Filed in January, the issue is a ₹1,500 crore offer for sale by an Edelweiss group entity. The company is present in what it calls real assets or which invests in a mix of equity, quasi-equity and debt instruments, and private

ness, while special situations are the harder capability to build," said Amit Agarwal, chief executive officer (CEO) of EAAA India Alternatives.

Special situations funds offer tailored financing solutions for unique circumstances, such as acquisitions, restructurings, or significant corporate events and can involve a combination of debt and equity features.

Agarwal said alternatives have a few things going for it. First is rising private wealth in India.

Second is the penetration of wealth management in that private wealth space. Finally, that private wealth is looking for income and yield. Agarwal said a ₹500 crore family office would predominantly look for growth to become a ₹500 crore family office. However, once it becomes a ₹500 crore family office, it would not want to put ₹400 crore into growth to make it ₹4,000 crore.

The company sees a host of opportunities for the alternative business in India. According to its draft prospectus, alternatives as a share of India's gross domestic product (GDP) was at 3.6% in 2024 and is expected to reach 4.16% in 2030. While PE currently dominates the mix, private credit is expected to close the difference by 2030.

"We actually have really democratized it for HNIs (high-net-worth individuals) and Indian investors. We wanted to give Indian access to 14-15% kind of returns that is by and large available to global capital," said Shah.

In January, Crisil Ratings reaffirmed EAAA's long-term debt rating of A+, saying the ratings continue to be supported by the Edelweiss group's adequate capitalization and diversified business risk profile with good market position in the asset reconstruction and asset management businesses.

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Coforge sees \$5 bn revenue within reach before FY30

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Coforge Ltd remains confident it will more than double revenue and cross \$5 billion well before its target of FY30, dismissing concerns that artificial intelligence (AI) will slow the growth of India's \$300-billion information technology services industry.

In an exclusive conversation with *Mint* on Friday, the chief executive of the country's seventh-largest software services firm said it remains open to acquisitions to meet its ambitions. "Our intent will be to be \$5 billion much before FY30. If that warrants acquisitions along the way, we will consider them, but at this point in time, the organic growth engine, which is doing extremely well and is trying to address the AI opportunity, is humming along very nicely," said Sudhir Singh.

Coforge ended FY26 with \$1.87 billion in revenue, up 29% on a yearly basis. This

India's seventh-largest software services firm said it remains open to acquisitions to meet its ambitions

Singh, who completed a decade at the top next May, is one of Indian IT's longest-serving CEOs. Under his tenure, Coforge clocked 20% compound annual revenue growth, which is among the highest in the country's IT services sector.

The Noida-based company expects business from legacy modernization to help scale growth. This comes after it



Coforge chief executive Sudhir Singh.

completed its biggest acquisition in April—that of California-based IT firm Encora for about \$2.35 billion.

To be sure, Coforge does not share how much of its revenue came from acquisitions. Still, management feels it could have done better. "What we could have done better, I suspect, is we could have grown even more than we have," Singh said, adding that the company had done a "decent job" on that front.

Coforge, according to Kotak Institutional Equities analysts, reported organic growth of 19.4% on a constant currency basis in FY26. It did not outline its constant currency growth, which takes currency fluctuations into account.

Despite this optimism, Coforge risks falling behind in the sector rankings after ninth-ranked Persistent Systems Ltd announced its plan to acquire Nagarro in June. The combined entity's projected revenue of \$2.9 billion would eclipse Coforge's stated target of \$2.5 billion by the end of the current fiscal year. Singh, however, declined to comment on competitors' strategies.

For now, Singh brushed off concerns about AI-driven revenue loss, despite client expectations for upfront cost savings as automation reduces reliance on billable hours.

"As far as the deflation is concerned, in the short term, in the medium term, and in the long term, and we are on record as having said this, we do not see deflation in play," said Singh, adding that deflation was only in the managed services portfolio.

He said the demand surrounding legacy modernization was offsetting AI-led deflation and the firm was gaining market share from peers. "There is no limit, and when I say no limit, obviously this is hyperbole of sorts. But there is incredible demand for creating data pipelines, there is incredible demand for context engineering, there is significant demand that is emerging these days around remediation engineering," he added.

"Just think the opportunity ahead of us, irrespective of the commentary around us, is so massive that the firms that pivot the fastest and make the promise of AI real for enterprises, will be operating in a context that is supply-constrained, not demand-constrained," said Singh.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.



IFAC president Jean Bouquot (left) and CEO Lee White.

'AI fears are fading, but auditors must hold human edge'

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Feared of auditors losing their jobs to artificial intelligence (AI) have considerably subsided, but accountants must adopt technology rapidly while retaining core human skills and professional ethics to attain audit excellence, said two top executives of the US-based International Federation of Accountants (IFAC) in an interview with *Mint*.

Lee White, chief executive officer (CEO) of the global body, flagged the rapidly evolving nature of AI and advised auditors to embrace it to upgrade their skills and generate insights. But public trust in their work is something that auditors must continue to earn through ethical practices.

The intersection of AI and auditing has come under the spotlight as technological advances not only make it easier for both auditors and auditees to source and use information quickly, but can also influence auditors' judgements.

It has prompted audit watchdogs worldwide to weigh the need for new regulations to ensure that this intersection doesn't lead to unintended consequences. Gaps in AI adoption remain

stark across countries, too.

The US's Public Company Accounting Oversight Board recently asked stakeholders if it should explore standard-setting in this area. India's National Financial Reporting Authority, in July, issued "general principles" on AI adoption, encouraging the use of the latest tools but emphasizing that the ultimate audit quality responsibility lies solely with the auditor.

Jean Bouquot, president of IFAC, said accountants need to exercise their professional scepticism in pursuit of audit excellence.

The global body has 188 members, mainly top accounting institutions of various countries, with the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) being one of the founding members.

Both White and Bouquot were in New Delhi to attend the IFAC's board meeting between 2 and 3 September, a first for India, during which technological transformation and the country's role in driving tech-led innovation were among the key issues under discussion.

White said accountancy has "always been a technology-led profession". "But this (AI) is quite rapid, he added.

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National Olympiad Programme 2026-2027
in Astronomy, Biology, Chemistry, Physics, Junior Science

All students wishing to participate in the programme must appear in corresponding **National Standard Examinations (NSEs)** (for science subjects) on **November 21 and 22, 2026**, conducted by the **Indian Association of Physics Teachers (IAPT)**.

Qualification in NSE is the first step towards participation in the corresponding **International Olympiads of 2027**.

To enroll:
NSEs: <https://www.iapt.org.in> (Aug 21-Sep 14, 2026)
For more details: <https://olympiads.hbcse.tifr.res.in>
<https://www.iapt.org.in>

CBC 48143/11/0006/2627

BRIHANMUMBAI MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
Department : Hydraulic Engineer's Department
No.E.E.(M.)M.W./2842 /Maint. dtd. 04-09-2026

e-Tender Notice

The Commissioner of Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation invites online tenders for the following works from the eligible bidders. The Bid start date and time and Bid End Date and Time is specified in the detailed tender notice on B.M.C's website under Tender Section and Mahatender Portal.

Sr. No.	Bid No.	Name of the Work
1.	2026_MCGM_1334761_1	Carrying out the work of simulation study, pre calibration & fixed calibration and analysis of the existing water supply system of the selected area of BMC on pilot basis along with relevant model building reports. (Date of issue & sale of tender- 07.09.2026)

The intending tenderers shall visit the BMC website at <http://portal.mcgm.gov.in> and Mahatenders portal website at <http://mahatenders.gov.in> for further details of the tender.

PRO/1332/ADV/2026-27
AVOID SELF MEDICATION

Sd/-
E.E. (Maint.) M.W.



Govt weighs sops for electric truck battery swaps

FROM PAGE 1

e-trucks are also being discussed with the industry now, for this particular scheme," said a government official, one of the people cited above.

An industry executive, who also asked not to be named, said manufacturers remain concerned about whether electric trucks with battery-swapping capabilities will qualify for incentives under PM E-Drive. "That is why we are trying to make sure that those same concerns are not repeated under the new EV financing scheme for e-trucks," the executive said.

Queries emailed to the ministry of heavy industries and battery-swapping electric truck maker Montra Electric remained unanswered.

India had 67,657 EV charging stations and 1,139 battery-swapping stations as of 7 August, per government data. But most swapping stations are designed for smaller EVs such as two- and three-wheelers, industry stakeholders said.

Heavy commercial EVs use batteries with capacities of over 250 kilowatt-hours, with individual battery packs weighing around two tonnes. The rollout of electric trucks under PM E-Drive has so far been limited. As of 6 September, only 52 electric trucks had got subsidies, according to the scheme's dashboard.

Tarun Kapoor, adviser in the Prime Minister's Office, said last week at the annual convention of the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers that India needs to



India had 67,657 EV charging stations as of 7 August. REUTERS

move toward electric mobility "in a big way," with trucks a particular focus. "My main concern is heavy vehicles, particularly trucks. Because unless we do something about that sector, diesel remains a major bottleneck," he said.

The proposed financing scheme could help bridge the gap for truck battery-swapping, said Amit Bhatt, India managing director at the International Council on Clean Transportation.

The move comes as Prime Minister Narendra Modi's administration seeks to reduce diesel use in freight transport

"Since the scheme is reportedly providing financing benefits such as interest subvention, e-trucks with battery-swapping capability should also be eligible," Bhatt said. The incentives are intended to offset part of the upfront capital cost, he said, adding that trucks sold without batteries should also be covered.

Electric trucks sold without batteries are not eligible now, a Blue Energy Motors spokesperson said, seeking parity between fixed-battery and battery-swapping models.

Amara Raja is latest in firms paying brand fee to owners

Family-owned Amara Raja Enterprises Pvt. Ltd got ₹6.76 cr from listed company in FY26

Ayaan Kartik
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NEW DELHI

Amara Raja Energy & Mobility Ltd has begun paying royalty to a privately held company controlled by its promoter family, adding a new payment from the listed battery maker to its largest shareholder group.

The company paid ₹6.76 crore in royalty to Amara Raja Enterprises Pvt. Ltd in the year ended March 2026, according to filings reviewed by *Mint*. The payment was equivalent to 0.05% of the company's ₹13,814 crore revenue and 0.8% of its ₹896 crore net profit during that period. The privately held entity, formerly known as RN Galla Family Pvt. Ltd, holds a 32.9% stake in the listed company.

The payment comes as Indian business families increasingly seek to formalize and monetize the value of their brand names. The Aditya Birla Group, for instance, recently introduced a brand royalty under which listed companies including Grasim Industries Ltd, Hindalco Industries Ltd and Novelis Inc. will pay the promoter group 0.25% of revenue, subject to a cap. The move followed similar arrangements at some other large Indian business groups.

For Amara Raja, however, the timing and rationale of the payment raise a different set of questions. The listed company has used the Amara Raja name for years, but the royalty payment to the promoter-owned entity appears to be new. Its filings don't separately explain what the royalty covers, when the agreement was signed or how the payment is calculated.

Amara Raja Enterprises owns the Amara Raja trademark, according to



The payment comes as Indian business families increasingly seek to formalize and monetize the value of their brand names.

publicly available trademark records, although *Mint* couldn't independently establish that the ₹6.76 crore payment was specifically for use of the brand. Amara Raja Energy & Mobility didn't respond to requests for comment.

the Galla family's ownership. In early 2025, founder Ramachandra Naidu Galla transferred the promoter company's shares into four family trusts as part of a succession arrangement. The trusts now collectively hold the pro-

Raja Infra Pvt. Ltd, an engineering procurement and construction company, and Mangal Industries Pvt. Ltd, an auto-components maker. Its standalone business also includes a foods operation.

To be sure, royalty is not entirely new to the Amara Raja group. The listed company had earlier charged royalty to its electronics business until 2016-17, before that arrangement was discontinued. What is different now is the direction of the payment: the listed company is paying a promoter-controlled entity.

"The fact that this is the first time the listed company is paying royalty to the promoter-owned entity is, in my view, the key issue," Sonam Chandwani, managing partner at KS Legal & Associates, said.

ROYALTY ARRANGEMENT

THE payment was equivalent to 0.05% of the firm's revenue and 0.8% of its FY26 ₹896 crore net profit

THE listed company has used the Amara Raja name for years, but royalty payment appears to be new

ITS filings don't explain what the royalty covers, when the deal was inked or how it was calculated

ROYALTY also comes against the backdrop of a broad revamp of the Galla family's ownership

The promoter entity was renamed Amara Raja Enterprises Pvt. Ltd from RN Galla Family Pvt. Ltd, according to the filings reviewed by *Mint*.

The royalty also comes against the backdrop of a broader restructuring of

motor entity, which remains the largest shareholder in the listed company.

The privately held Amara Raja Enterprises is itself a diversified business rather than a pure holding company. Its subsidiaries include Amara

An email revives ghost of a Tata Sons clean chit

FROM PAGE 1

Fund, had approached me, through Mr Mukhopadhyay, to make a presentation about investment with the Fund." He said he "quite impressed and made an investment".

He added that he "was not aware" that the Fund was owned by Mukhopadhyay's family. "I thought his daughter worked for the Fund. She did not at all suggest that the Fund was connected to the Tata Group."

"So I suggest that Noel, Venu and Vijay find out from Chandra and then keep us informed," wrote Khambata, referring to the then Trusts representatives on the Tata Sons board: Tata Trusts Chair Noel Tata, Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh.

To be sure, Khambata's investment was made before he took over as trustee. The email raises questions over how many current and former group executives had been solicited by Mukhopadhyay for his family's wealth-advisory business.

A Tata trustee said there is sufficient reason to start a new investigation now, including details of this email, and

whether the internal committee of the group had reviewed them.

"Darius Khambata did the right thing by flagging this, and asking the Trust's nominees to ask the Tata Sons chair to investigate this," said H.P. Ranina, a senior lawyer in the Supreme Court. "But the probe was done by employees of the Tata Group. Now, that is a problem because it is like the judge and the prosecutor are the same."

The lawyer said a fresh investigation is needed "right from the start, by independent people into this wealth advisory firm, so that all aspects—including all the current and former Tata Group employees whose money is managed by it—come out."

Emails sent to Tata Sons and Mukhopadhyay seeking comment went unanswered. An email sent to Tata Trusts, which owns 65.9% of Tata Sons, also did not elicit a reply.

The Tata Code of Conduct says a conflict of interest arises when an employee "is in a position to derive an improper benefit, personally or for any family member or for any person in a close personal relationship, by making or influencing decisions relating to any transac-



Legal experts also called for a fresh independent probe. BLOOMBERG

tion."

Within a week of *Mint*'s report, the group had set up a three-member committee comprising Nupur Mallick, head of Tata Sons human resources; Eru N. Kapadia, a finance executive; and Sidharth Sharma, general counsel, to probe the incident. Significantly, the panel did not contact Khambata, according to an executive familiar with the matter. *Mint* could not confirm whether Khambata's email had been submitted to

the panel.

In its report, the internal panel pointed to Mukhopadhyay's lapses but fell short of concluding he was guilty, and said his actions were "not intentional," *Mint* reported on 29 April 2025.

Khambata told *Mint* on Saturday: "I made payment for purchase of units of a fund floated/managed by Division Investment in late 2022, and from what I can ascertain these units appear to have been allotted on 1 January 2023."

A Tata trustee said there is sufficient reason to start a new probe now, including details of this email

Local pvt credit funds pull ahead of foreign rivals in mid-market

FROM PAGE 1

\$3.1 billion refinancing largely funded by offshore capital, disproportionately lifting the global share, said Ankur Jain, managing director of private credit strategies at InCred Alternative Investments.

Even after adjusting for that transaction, however, the shift toward domestic managers is significant, he said. "The drop is real, but it is more like 50 to 26 than 68 to 26," Jain said.

Local managers are gaining an edge particularly in the mid-market, where smaller-ticket transactions particularly in deals of \$10 million to \$60 million, are less attractive for offshore funds because of the

cost of underwriting and executing each deal, said Jain.

Domestic managers are also increasingly crowding into special situations offering returns of 18% or more, he said, adding that competition is intensifying in the segment.

Kotak Alternate's Karra said the real depth of the market has shifted towards this segment as private credit has expanded. "Global funds typically have higher return hurdles, larger cheque-size mandates and stricter risk frameworks, pushing them towards mega-deals or complex special situations," he added.

Meanwhile, domestic managers can underwrite mid-market growth, financing and

refinancing needs for holding companies with faster turnaround times, while structuring around local regulatory and cash-flow realities.

On the other hand, for offshore lenders, currency hedging is one of the hurdles. Dollar-based funds lending in rupees can face hedging costs of roughly 4-5%, making it harder for them to compete for performing-credit transactions unless the underlying returns are sufficiently high, InCred Alternative's Jain said.

That means an offshore lender may need returns in the high teens to achieve economics comparable with a domestic fund investing in rupees, Jain said.

Credit shift

The new power balance in India's private credit market.

Takeaway	Data / Number
Domestic funds dominate private-credit deal value in H1 2026	74% domestic; 26% global
Global share declines sharply in H1 2026, over same period last year	68% → 26%
Domestic and global funds have different sweet spots	\$10 mn–\$60 mn vs \$200 mn–\$250 mn+
Major domestic funds are raising large pools	Funds like Kotak, Neo, Asecrta, EAAA, and Avendus net over \$3 bn in dry powder to deploy in Private Credit deals in India
Offshore funds face higher costs on rupee exposure	4%–5%
Source: EV report; Mint reporting, other media reports	

Domestic managers can also move faster because investment teams and borrowers are typically in the same market.

"Domestic funds typically have decision-making teams based in India, allowing them to move faster and provide

greater certainty around closure," said Anshul Jain, executive director of private-credit strategies at Avendus.

The shift doesn't mean global lenders are disappearing. They continue to have an advantage in large-ticket financings and complex special situations, where their larger funds allow them to underwrite transactions that can be difficult for a single domestic manager to absorb.

Deals such as ongoing discussions with global private

credit funds for \$700 million Megha Engineering buyout in August and the Shapoorji Pallonji transaction in June show that international funds remain important at the upper end.

The result is less a retreat by global capital than a redistribution of the market. As Indian managers accumulate larger pools of capital and deepen their origination networks, they can increasingly compete for transactions below the mega-deal end of the market, while global funds

DOMESTIC EDGE

LOCAL managers are gaining an edge as offshore funds find smaller-ticket deals less attractive

LOCAL managers are also increasingly crowding into special situations offering 18% returns or more

ingly compete for transactions below the mega-deal end of the market, while global funds



Consumption of key petroleum products such as petrol and diesel also increased. AFP

India's crude oil import price nears \$100/bbl

Rajeev Jayaswal
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NEW DELHI

India's average crude oil import price rose to nearly \$100 a barrel, its highest level in three months, amid renewed volatility in global oil markets, while consumption of key petroleum products such as petrol and diesel also increased, according to government and industry data.

The price of the Indian crude basket was \$99.35 a barrel on Wednesday, according to the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC), and is expected to cross the \$100-mark by Friday amid renewed hostilities between the US and Iran, industry experts said. PPAC, the petroleum ministry's data keeper, publishes data on the Indian basket with a lag. The basket represents an average of the various grades of crude imported by Indian refiners, including Brent, Oman and Dubai.

Benchmark Brent crude gained nearly 1% on Friday to close at \$96.28 a barrel, while West Texas Intermediate crude settled at \$91.48, up 18

Hindustan Times

cents. Both benchmarks gained over 9% during the week as the US-Iran conflict escalated.

Other factors contributing to the rise in global crude oil and petroleum product prices include a fall in US energy inventories and Ukraine's attacks on Russian refineries, experts said. As a result, India's average petrol benchmark rose to a three-month high of \$120.65 a barrel in September 2026 as of Thursday, while the average diesel benchmark rose to a four-month high of \$156.44 as of September 3, according to latest data.

Experts said that if international oil prices continue to rise, state-run oil companies could seek the government's approval to raise petrol and diesel pump prices, particularly as domestic consumption is also increasing.

India imports over 88% of the crude oil it processes. However, retail petrol and diesel prices have largely been insulated from extreme international price volatility, with state-run oil marketing companies, which control over 90% of the nation's 103,023 petrol pumps, keeping pump prices largely unchanged.



The closing auction session debuted on 3 August. REUTERS

Sebi may float old model for expiry

FROM PAGE 1

the continuous trading session (CTS) for eligible cash stocks closes at 3:15 pm, while derivatives trading in these 213 stocks continues until 3:40 pm. Under CAS, orders can be placed between 3:20 pm and 3:30 pm, with closing prices discovered based on maximum bids and offers between 3:28 pm and 3:30 pm. These prices, from which derivatives would take cues, are released at 3:35 pm and used for the settlement of derivatives at 3:40 pm.

On settlement days of Sensx or Nifty, there would be a divergence between the two indices when relatively thinly traded CAS prices are used in large-value derivatives settlements.

A key reason for the divergence between indices under CAS is the low presence of arbitrage traders and funds and retail investors. Arbitrageurs step in to buy the cheaper stock in one exchange and sell it at a higher price on the other, or exploit price differences between spot stocks and their derivatives, profiting from the

gap narrowing while smoothing out price differences.

These traders execute buying and selling simultaneously, but under CAS, the final price is known only at 3:35 pm, preventing such arbitrage trades. Retail investors, meanwhile, often place limit orders outside the 3% upper or lower band for CAS stocks, based on their reference rates determined at 3:15 pm. This leaves the short 20-minute window dominated by thin, institutional orders, and prone to divergences between stocks and indices on the two exchanges.

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Modern Bazaar halves stores as q-comm eats into grocery

The NCR retailer's store count fell to 14 from 28-30, with more closures under consideration

Varuni Khosla & Soumya Gupta
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

Modern Bazaar, one of Delhi-NCR's oldest premium grocery retailers, is restructuring its store network as the rapid rise of quick commerce is forcing traditional supermarkets to rethink the size, location and economics of retail stores. The ₹250-crore turnover retailer, which operated 28-30 stores till a year or ago, now has around 14, with more outlets being evaluated for closure or relocation, its founders told *Mint*.

The retailer, which has been around for five decades, however, said it is not exiting physical retail. "We are trying to restructure the business, so that we are more profitable and are able to deal with the new headwinds that quick commerce is bringing," said Vedika Kumar, a member of the founding family, and advisory board member to Modern Bazaar Departmental Stores Pvt. Ltd. "We are trying to build a business that can sustain, and not only sustain, but excel in this new space."

The gourmet retail chain has shut its stores in posh Defence Colony, Select CityWalk mall, Saket and New Friends Colony, among other areas. Its Aerocity location is also shut but will be replaced by another at a close location. "Consumer landscape is changing. We are trying to figure out how to position ourselves best for the future," she said.

Modern Bazaar will continue to operate large-format outlets in some locations, but future locations and store sizes will be decided more selectively and based on profitability and consumer demand. "We are wondering if we need a large store like the one we had in Select CityWalk mall."



Modern Bazaar is rethinking large-format stores, with future locations and store sizes to be determined by profitability and consumer demand. MINT

"Our Express store format has seen a success," Kumar said, adding that the firm plans to open more such stores across Delhi-NCR, and eventually in other locations. Small stores have lower rentals and cater to a different consumer segment, she said. Express

entiate retailers such as Modern Bazaar from conventional supermarkets.

The firm does not intend to compete with quick-commerce companies on delivery speed, but will look to complement them in some way. "I don't think we can, and the strategy is never to

merch offering that is not really focused on minutes, but helps keep the loyalty of the consumer in-house," she said.

Its operating revenue rose from ₹232.7 crore in FY21 to ₹288 crore in FY23, before remaining broadly flat in FY24 and falling 13.6% to ₹247.2 crore in FY25, according to data from Toller. Its net profit, too, fell to ₹1.43 crore in FY25 from ₹2.62 crore a year earlier, translating into a margin of about 0.6%. Modern Bazaar's rivals are FoodStories, Nature's Basket and Le Marche.

Many of the supermarket chain's woes come from gross mismanagement, said a senior industry executive privy to the company's functioning.

"Modern Bazaar stores are pretty badly managed," this executive told *Mint*, requesting anonymity. "They don't have basic controls and structures in place. There are gaps between reported and actual inventory, and a lot of expired stock."

The executive alleged ethics issues. "They have a practice of mislabeling goods with new expiry dates. And there are no controls in place, which leaves the company vulnerable to theft from employees and financial misgovernance." Moreover, the company is practically a one-man show, he added.

"There is no professional management. They relied on a bunch of old, trusted hands, which is not a very suitable way to run a business when you have quick commerce and e-commerce in this segment. It is okay if you run 4-5 stores."

While the firm does not intend to compete with quick commerce, it has not managed to offer online delivery. Besides, it is facing pressure from suppliers following payment defaults.

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For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

'Regional festivals are clearly emerging as national stories'

Soumya Gupta

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MUMBAI



For years, India's biggest consumer firms have run Diwali and Dussehra specials alongside local campaigns around regional festivals. But as these festivals gain national recognition, companies are getting more serious about engaging with their cultural codes. This year, ITC Foods ran its most intensive campaign yet at Puri's Jagannath Yatra in Odisha. Shuvadip Banerjee, chief marketing officer, ITC Foods, speaks about changing festive pride and how brands are engaging with regional festivals more authentically.

Many food brands are using festivals to create product experiences. What has been your approach this year?

The central question for doing any big campaign is that if my brand were not there, would that engagement be equally interesting for someone? A lot of money spent on media can get you reach, but when you experience the brand in a relevant context, you retain much more about the brand. For example, with noodles. We could have created a stall, made hot noodles and sold it. But we thought, after offering prayers and being in the arena, where do people go? To the beach to get entertained. Can I engage with these people better there? We created a theme around the Odia phrase *Basa Masare Tera Parba* (12 months, 13 festivals) to offer 13 traditional dishes but with Yippee noodles. For example, we did a traditional stuffed parwal but with noo-

dles. We had also done this theme two years ago too – 51 dishes of the traditional Rath Yatra prasad made with noodles. But the dishes were not integrated with traditional Odia flavours.

How else are you integrating food into regional festival culture?

During this year's Durga Puja, we are thinking about a more intensive campaign. For example, when you exit a pujo pandal, can we make an alley where you can sample pan-Asian noodles in the street style of Vietnam, Thailand, Indonesia? We are planning this campaign for Yippee noodles. Kolkata also has a long history of Chinese food and a very old Chinese origin community. We are working on a campaign for Bingo Tedhe Medhe (extruded snack brand) with Sukumar Ray's *Abol Tabol*, the iconic collection of children's rhymes, celebrating "tedhapan" or life. It is all about fun, and fun is one of the pillars of the Bingo brand.

How have regional festivals changed, and how are national brands changing?

There is a diffusion of people from one state to others. For example, look at the size of the Bengali community in, say, Bengaluru. Every large city has become more cosmopolitan. A couple of years ago, we tried to see if national news coverage was interested in the story of the Puri Rath Yatra. We were pleasantly surprised that people outside, not just migrants from the state, were consuming the content, wanting to know the legends associ-

The key question for any campaign is if my brand were not there, will the engagement be equally interesting

Shuvadip Banerjee
Chief digital marketing officer, ITC Ltd

ated with the festival, and details of the Sri Jagannath Puri Temple. So, culture codes are spreading for different reasons. The curiosity to understand (each other's festivals) has grown by leaps and bounds. As a brand, we are not just in Durga Puja in Kolkata but across West Bengal. We are at a Puri Rath Yatra, while a Bali Yatra (Bali Jatra) in Odisha is equally important. We are in Chhath Puja in Bihar, Bihu in Assam, and Onam in Kerala.

Paint firms expect healthy demand despite price hikes

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Leading paint manufacturers expect double-digit growth to continue into the festive season even as they push through fresh price increases to offset input cost pressures, and the fierce competitive intensity across price segments in the sector shows no signs of easing.

Companies, including Asian Paints, Berger Paints, Kansai Nerolac and JSW Dulux expect sustained demand from housing, infrastructure and automotive sectors, though they also remain wary of uncertainty in crude-linked raw material costs amid geopolitical tensions as the bulk of their production costs rely on petroleum-derived resources.

Berger and JSW projected double-digit growth and Asian Paints guided for 8-10% volume growth in FY27. The top leadership of the leading listed paintmaker in latest earnings calls reported healthy growth in the June quarter and indicated that price hikes taken in the first quarter will continue to support revenues in coming months.

Asian Paints CEO and managing director Amit Syngle said demand conditions were decent through the quarter and the firm continues to expect volume growth of 8-10% in FY27. "We are entering a festive quarter. September is good enough from some festive sales. As we even look at Q3 and Q4, overall, we have given direction that we should stay in the volume region of about 8-10%," he said.

Asian Paints, India's largest paint maker, reported a 39.6% rise in consolidated net profit at ₹1,559.45 crore for the June quarter of FY27, with revenue from operations rising 18% to ₹10,541.94 crore.

Syngle said demand condi-



Recent price hikes by firms will support revenue growth.

tions were also decent, though growth in metro and large urban markets (T1, T2) trailed that in smaller towns (T3, T4), a shortfall he said was offset by strong government-led B2B spending in bigger cities.

On competition, Syngle said rivalry was intense "across the board" — economy, premium and luxury segments alike — and predicted it could sharpen further in the economy segment, where heavier discounting helps convert contractors.

Paint-makers expect double-digit growth in festive months, supported by infrastructure, housing and auto

He said the gap between economy and premium in competitive pressure "is not much different." Similarly, Berger Paints MD and CEO Abhijit Roy expects double-digit revenue growth to sustain through FY27, on the back of the full quarterly impact of price hikes taken in the second quarter. He said: "Volume growth will beat similar level even with Q1, slightly below maybe, so we were at 8.5%, maybe it will be 7.5 to 8%, and a price increase, varying from 7.5 to 8.59%."

Kansai Nerolac Paints managing director Pravin Chaudhari said geopolitical conflicts, supply-chain disruptions, elevated crude oil prices, uncertainty over raw material availability, rupee depreciation and higher import costs are still key risks for the sector.

PARBHANI CITY MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, PARBHANI
(WATER SUPPLY DEPARTMENT)
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E-Tender Notice No. 2247 for 2026-27

Parbhani City Municipal Corporation invites e-tender for the work of Underground Sewerage system Project for Parbhani City under AMRUT 2.0 (Second Call). The cost of tender is Rs.343,36,51,231/- (Excluding Gst Tax). The detailed tender document is available at <http://www.mahatenders.gov.in> from 07/09/2026. The right to accept and cancel the tender at any stage has been reserved by the Commissioner, Parbhani City Municipal Corporation.

Date: 04/09/2026 **Dy. Commissioner**
Parbhani City Municipal Corporation

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NOTICE OF 27TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

In compliance with the applicable provisions of Companies Act, 2013, Rules framed thereunder, and Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("SEBI LODR Regulations") read with Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") General Circular dated September 22, 2025 and other relevant Circulars issued by MCA and Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") from time to time (hereinafter collectively referred to as "Circulars"), **NOTICE** is hereby given that the 27th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation Limited ("IRCTC" / "Company") will be held on **Tuesday, September 29, 2026 at 03:00 P.M. (IST)** through Video Conferencing ("VC") / Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM"), without the physical presence of the members of the Company, to transact the business set out in the Notice of the AGM ("Notice").

The Company has engaged the service of National Securities Depository Limited ("NSDL") as the agency for providing the facilities for participation in the AGM through VC/OAVM facility, voting through remote e-voting and e-voting during the AGM. Members will be able to attend the AGM through VC/OAVM facility at www.evoting.nsdl.com. Members participation through VC/OAVM shall be reckoned for the purpose of quorum under section 103 of the Companies Act, 2013.

In compliance with aforesaid Circulars of MCA & SEBI, the Notice of the 27th AGM along with Annual Report 2025-26 will be sent through electronic mode only to those Members whose email addresses are registered with the Company / Alankit Assignments Limited, the Registrar & Share Transfer Agent of Company ("RTA") / Depositories / Depository Participants.

The aforesaid documents will also be available on the websites of the Company (i.e. www.irctc.com), Stock Exchanges, viz., BSE Limited (i.e. www.bseindia.com) and National Stock Exchange of India Limited (i.e. www.nseindia.com) and National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL) (agency for providing the remote e-voting facility and e-voting system during AGM) (i.e. www.evoting.nsdl.com). A member can also request for the physical copy of the Annual Report 2025-26 by sending a requisition at investors@irctc.com.

Pursuant to Regulation 36(1)(b) of SEBI LODR Regulations, a letter providing the web-link for accessing the Annual Report 2025-26, including the exact path, will be sent to those Members who have not registered their email address with the Company / RTA / Depositories / Depository Participants.

Manner of casting vote through e-voting:
Members who hold shares in physical form or who have not registered their e-mail addresses and wish to participate in the AGM or cast their votes through remote e-voting or e-voting during the AGM can log on to the e-voting website www.evoting.nsdl.com by using their credentials. Members are requested to read instructions contained in the Notice of AGM to be made available on the website of the Company/Stock Exchanges.

Dividend, Record Date and Tax on Dividend:
Members may further note that the Board of Directors of the Company at their meeting held on May 26, 2026 has recommended final dividend of ₹0.50/- per share on the face value of ₹2.00 per share, subject to approval of the Shareholders at the 27th AGM. The Company has fixed **Tuesday, September 22, 2026, as the 'Record Date'** for determining entitlement of members for final dividend for the financial year ended March 31, 2026, if approved at the AGM.

Pursuant to the provisions of Income Tax Act, 2025 ("Income Tax Act"), as amended, payment of dividend will be subject to deduction of tax at source (TDS) at applicable rates. In order to enable us to determine the appropriate TDS rate, members are requested to submit the relevant documents in accordance with the provisions of the Act. A detailed notice regarding "Communication w.r.t. Tax Deducted at Source (TDS) on Final Dividend for the Financial Year 2025-26" is hosted at the website of the Company, www.irctc.com. For more details, please refer to the Notice of the Notice of 27th AGM.

Manner of registering KYC details including email addresses, bank details for receiving Dividend electronically, if declared in the AGM:
Pursuant to SEBI's Master Circular dated February 06, 2026, has mandated the security holder (holding securities in physical form), whose folio(s) are not updated with the KYC details including PAN, Choice of Nomination, Contact Details, Postal Address with PIN code, Mobile Number, Bank Account Details, and Specimen Signature (if any), shall be eligible for any payment including Dividend, only through electronic mode with effect from April 01, 2024.

In view of above, Members are requested to follow the below mentioned procedure for registration/ update of their KYC details.

In case of, Physical Holding	Members holding physical shares are requested to register/update their email addresses and Electronic Clearing Service ("ECS") mandate with complete Bank details by sending a duly signed request letter in Form ISR-1 along with supporting documents to the RTA of the Company i.e. Alankit Assignments Limited, Alankit House, 4E/2 Jhandewalan Extension, Near Jhandewalan Metro Station, New Delhi - 110055, or scanned copy on email at kycupdate@alankit.com through their registered mail ID and provide the following details/documents: 1. For registering email address: a) Folio No.; b) Name of shareholder; c) Email ID; d) Mobile No; e) Copy of PAN card (self attested); f) Copy of Address Proof (self-attested); and g) Copy of share certificate (front and back). 2. For updating Bank Account details: a) Name and Branch of the Bank in which you wish to receive the dividend; b) the Bank Account type; c) Bank Account Number; d) MICR Code Number; e) IFSC Code; and f) Copy of the cancelled cheque / Passbook bearing the name of the first shareholder. 3. Members may please note that the documents for KYC update may be sent through self attested and dated in hard copies to the above-mentioned address of RTA or through electronic mode, provided that these are sent through E-mail ID of the holder registered with RTA and all documents should be self-attested by the Shareholder and in case of Joint holders, by first Joint holder
In case, Demat Holding	Please contact your Depository Participant (DP) and register your email address and bank account details in your demat account, as per the process advised by your DP.

In case of any queries/ grievances regarding attending AGM & e-Voting from the NSDL e-Voting System, you can write an email to evoting@nsdl.com or contact at toll free no. 022 - 4886 7000. Members may also write an email to company at investors@irctc.com.

By order of the Board of Directors of IRCTC
Sd/-
(Suman Kalra)
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Place : New Delhi
Dated : September 05, 2026

Iran says it will deal with US sanctions

US strikes three Iranian vessels after Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps fires ballistic missiles at two US Navy ships

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com

Iran said it will step up efforts to tackle problems created by the US sanctions that are crippling its economy, while a senior Iranian official warned of a "painful response" if it comes under further attack.

Six months after US-Israeli strikes against Iran, the war appears to be at a stalemate. A preliminary ceasefire accord reached in June has unravelled and little progress has been made in diplomatic efforts to get the peace process back on track.

After a pause in military action for much of August, tit-for-tat strikes have resumed with US Central Command saying it hit three Iranian tankers on Saturday in response to Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) launching ballistic missiles at two US Navy ships.

Following the attacks, Iran's Parliament Speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf said on Sunday that the US should understand that the rules of the game in the war against Iran have changed "before it is too late".

"From now on, any attack against Iran's interests and security will receive a faster, heavier and more painful response," he said in a speech published on his Telegram channel.

Tehran has shown it still retains the capability to attack U.S. interests in neighbouring countries and to shut down oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz, through which a fifth of global oil supplies flowed prior to the conflict.

However, the US campaign to throttle

Iran's economy by blockading its oil exports and stopping sanctions evasion is growing increasingly difficult to withstand, three senior Iranian sources have said.

In his speech on Sunday, Qalibaf added that alongside the military front, Iran's main battle was now over production and people's livelihoods.

He cited sharp currency fluctuations, inflation, unemployment and market management as major challenges, adding Iranians could tolerate hardship but not mismanagement or inaction and expected the government to act quickly.

Iran's Economy Minister Ali Madanizadeh said that Tehran planned to respond to US economic pressure with reforms and rejected the idea that sanctions would cause it to change course, according to state media on Sunday.

"They speak of economic pressure and isolation, of breaking off financial ties and they think that by pressuring the economy of a country they can change the decisions of its people," Madanizadeh said.

"I have to clarify one point: the responsibility of reforming Iran's economy is with its government and people, not with the US Treasury."

Separately, Economy Ministry deputy Morteza Zamanian said on Sunday that the ministry's "Economic War Headquarters" was doubling down on its work to resolve problems caused by the war, according to the semi-official Tasnim news agency.

Iran is the third-largest producer in the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and exported 90% of its crude



After a pause in military action for much of August, tit-for-tat strikes have resumed with US Central Command saying it hit three Iranian tankers on Saturday. AFP

via its Kharg Island export hub before the war. Flows have been disrupted since a US blockade of Iranian oil exports began in mid-April.

On 31 August, US President Trump issued a one-line social media post accompanied by an AI-generated video depicting Kharg Island being "blown to smithereens."

Iranian authorities have vowed a strong

response if Kharg is attacked.

In an interview aired on state TV on Sunday, Iran's Oil Minister Mohsen Paknejad said the island had been hit around 550 times in previous months but continued to operate.

Iran has also imposed a blockade on the Strait of Hormuz, creating an issue for US President Donald Trump by pushing up fuel prices globally ahead of midterm

elections for his Republican Party in November.

On Saturday, US Central Command said it struck three Iranian vessels, including one off the coast of Kharg Island, after Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps launched ballistic missiles at two US Navy ships.

"Let the message to the IRGC be clear: If you shoot at two of our ships, we will impose an even higher economic cost — taking out three of yours," said Admiral Brad Cooper, head of US Central Command, which oversees the US military in the Middle East.

The IRGC responded by threatening intensified strikes against U.S. military vessels in the region, and said later it targeted the three tankers as well as three US-linked vessels in other areas.

"Do not be deceived by the 'terrorist' US military and refrain from any suspicious movement aimed at passing through unauthorized waterways," the IRGC Navy said in a statement carried on Iranian state TV. "Otherwise, you will be targeted."

Tasnim, the semi-official Iranian news agency, had reported that four U.S. missiles hit a tanker in the area of Kharg's anchorage. Tasnim quoted local sources as saying there were no casualties and the tanker's crew was being evacuated.

No American personnel were harmed, Central Command said.

On Sunday, Tasnim reported that the IRGC had shot down a US surveillance balloon over Erbil in northern Iraq, describing it as part of a broader effort to eliminate US aerial surveillance and early-warning systems in the region.

Israeli strikes kill four in southern Lebanon

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com

Israeli strikes killed four people, including two women, in southern Lebanon on Sunday, the Lebanese health ministry said, as Israel retaliated for what it said were Hezbollah drone attacks within areas occupied by its troops.

Despite a US-brokered ceasefire with Hezbollah agreed in June, the Israeli military is operating in what it has declared as a security zone in southern Lebanon.

Lebanon's health ministry said that two men were killed in a town on the edge of the zone occupied by Israeli troops, while the two women were killed in Arab Salim, which sits well north of the occupied area.

The Israeli military had issued an online evacuation warning at 6 a.m. local (0300 GMT) for areas near a building in Arab Salim that it said it would strike because it was being used by Hezbollah. Two girls were among six injured in that strike.

Ukraine considers legalizing porn industry to fund its war chest

Matthew Luxmoore
feedback@livemint.com
KYIV, UKRAINE

Every few weeks, Svitlana Dvornikova leaves her home near the front line in Ukraine and travels to a rented luxury villa on the Mediterranean coast of France or Spain.

She dons makeup, a wig, high heels and a pseudonym.

Dvornikova isn't there to escape the war. She travels abroad to stream solo shows to her one million subscribers on the adult online platform OnlyFans. Doing it in Ukraine could land her in jail.

Unlike in most European countries, the production, distribution and possession of pornography in Ukraine is illegal, punishable by up to seven years in prison. Still, Ukraine has been unable to curtail a vast and lucrative porn industry, which officials say operates with the protection of corrupt police.

Ukrainian authorities are now demanding taxes from people who work in the porn industry. But anyone who complies is effectively confirming their involvement in criminal activity.

"These women either don't pay taxes and face criminal charges for that, or they pay taxes and get charged with violating pornography laws," said Yaroslav Zhelezniak, an opposition lawmaker who chairs the finance committee in Ukraine's Parliament. "It's a tragicomic situation."

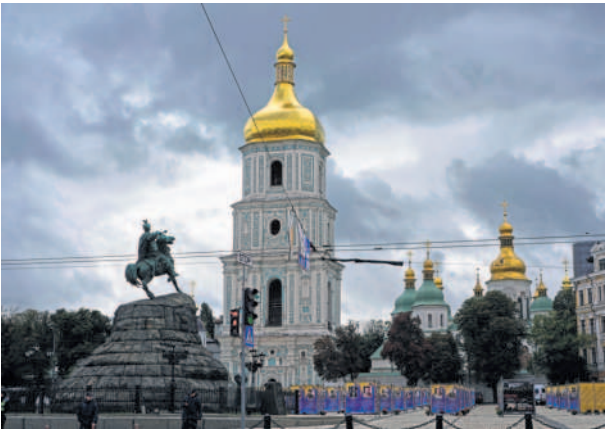
Zhelezniak is now leading a push to legalize porn in Ukraine, arguing that doing so wouldn't only help against corruption, but would raise up to \$25 million a year in tax revenues.

It might be a drop in the ocean for a country fighting a war of survival that says it needs \$120 billion a year for its defense needs. But the sum that Zhelezniak predicts would be enough to pay for 30,000 drones.

A bill co-authored by Zhelezniak is awaiting its second reading in Parliament after winning a first vote in July.

Meanwhile, Dvornikova is one of thousands of women who skirt the law by operating abroad or moving out of Ukraine altogether to make porn—many of them boosting the tax revenues of other countries instead.

"This is a victimless crime," said Lesia Mykhalenko, a tax



Lawmakers say taxing the country's thousands of OnlyFans models could collect \$25 million a year. AP

lawyer who has represented more than 100 OnlyFans models. "It unnecessarily burdens the legal system at a time when we should be focused on defending the country."

For years, Ukrainian authorities turned a blind eye to the shadowy industry. Many of Ukraine's largest porn studios made handsome profits in cahoots with corrupt law-enforcement agents. In one recent example, the office of Ukraine's general prosecutor said in May that police departments in three separate regions had each been receiving over \$20,000 a month in bribes.

Things changed after Russia invaded. Two years into the war, Ukraine's tax authorities received data on thousands of Ukrainians from OnlyFans' U.K.-based parent company, Fenix International.

The figures showed that 7,900 Ukrainians made in excess of \$131 million from OnlyFans during 2023. That meant millions of dollars in taxes were owed.

OnlyFans models across Ukraine began receiving letters from the authorities. Some were making in excess of \$20,000 a month. Many, including Dvornikova, filed tax declarations. Unbeknown to them, this meant they could now be charged not only with tax evasion but with illicitly producing porn.

Dvornikova and her husband were getting their daughter ready for school one morning last spring when police arrived to search her home and accused her of breaking the law by producing pornography for profit. They seized a laptop, flash drives and the equivalent of \$200,000 in cash, which she said she had set aside for taxes.

"They had a list of webcam models, and knew all their

addresses," Dvornikova said in an interview. She said the officers told her she could give them half of the cash as a bribe and keep the rest. She declined the offer.

Similar searches were conducted across the country. One woman in her early 20s told the *Journal* that after police searched her apartment and charged her earlier this year, she went into hiding in another part of Ukraine. She said she was summoned to a court hearing by police, but decided not to go because she feared officials wanted to use the meeting to extract a bribe.

Hundreds of OnlyFans models have left to live abroad. One, who now lives in Georgia, said the small Caucasus country has a large community of Ukrainian OnlyFans models who make thousands of dollars each month and frequent swanky night clubs in its capital city, Tbilisi.

Those who have stayed inside Ukraine have resorted to workarounds.

Former waitress Iryna Mosychuk runs a company called Beezone, which advertises itself as a business consulting firm. "We create opportunities for those who strive for more," says its website, which is full of motivational slogans and reveals nothing about what Beezone actually does.

Its main office, inside a nondescript two-story building on the outskirts of Lviv in western Ukraine, is actually a collection of webcam studios, used by several dozen models who perform for mostly U.S.-based clients to the soundtrack of booming pop music.

The women monitor a smartphone app to track alerts for Russian airstrikes. Sometimes they have to interrupt livestreams and rush to the bomb shelter.

"Missiles are bad for busi-

ness," Mosychuk laments.

Mosychuk said her models earn between \$2,000 and \$7,000 a month. She helps pay their taxes. In return they sign contracts in which they promise not to take their clothes off on camera, although Mosychuk said she can't control them all. When police visited Beezone last year, Mosychuk said they found no evidence to charge her.

Mosychuk has written to Ukrainian lawmakers and government ministries arguing that the \$5,000 she pays in taxes each month could increase twentyfold if she were allowed to expand the business and stop trying to control what her women do behind closed doors.

"I don't want my country to ask other countries for support and weapons," she said. "If our industry was able to grow, I think we could help Ukraine manage all this on its own."

Dvornikova has been making the same case. In June 2025, after the police raid, she submitted a petition that was published on the website of Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky.

Describing herself as a "conscientious taxpayer," she said that instead of branding her a criminal, the government should be thankful for the 40,000,000 hryvnias, about \$900,000, she had paid in taxes—a sum she said was worth 100 new pickup trucks for the army, 2,000 drones or "hundreds of Russians killed on the front line."

Within a week, Dvornikova's petition had gathered the more than 25,000 signatures needed to trigger a response from Zelensky, who said Parliament would consider the legislation to legalize porn.

Dvornikova's case hasn't come to court. She said she was told it has been put on hold while Parliament considers the new law. Her confiscated cash has been returned.

For now, she continues to straddle two worlds, running a household in Ukraine and earning her online living abroad. Her OnlyFans account can't be viewed in Ukraine, meaning only her closest friends know her alter ego.

Other online presence, she said: "You know who I am in Ukraine, but you have no idea who I am there."

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Becky Peterson
feedback@livemint.com

Antonio Gracías and Steve Jurvetson made a fortune from their bets on SpaceX when it was still a risky space startup. That isn't the only long-shot wager the billionaires have placed.

Gracias and Jurvetson, who are directors at SpaceX and allies of Chief Executive Elon Musk, have spent millions of dollars on philanthropic efforts to mainstream psychedelic drugs, including MDMA, the drug commonly known as ecstasy and molly.

Last year, Gracias cut a \$25 million check from his family foundation to help recapitalize the pharmaceutical company Lykos Therapeutics, after federal regulators rejected its application for MDMA in conjunction with therapy to treat post-traumatic stress disorder, sending the company into a financial tailspin. Lykos had drawn criticism for missing serious side effects in some study subjects, including suicidal thoughts.

When Gracias took over, he renamed the company Resilient Pharmaceuticals and moved its headquarters to Chicago, which is also home to his investment firm Valor Equity Partners. Resilient is in talks to raise new funding and recently resubmitted a new drug application for MDMA to the Food and Drug Administration, people briefed on the plans said.

Gracias has also endowed a Harvard program with a \$16 million donation to fund a professorship and research on psychedelics in society and culture.

Jurvetson and his wife, Genevieve Jurvetson, have been some of the most high-profile supporters of psychedelic medicine. She is a board member of a nonprofit dedicated to advancing psychedelic philanthropy, and the couple previously donated from their family foundation to support the Lykos drug trials.

Musk's brother, Kimbal, who is a Tesla director, and his wife, Christiana Musk, have also funded research, including an academic fellowship to understand the effects of psychedelics in society.

Philanthropists looking to expand access to psychedelics



Elon Musk, who was prescribed ketamine to treat depression, has previously spoken of the benefits of psychedelics. REUTERS

have zeroed in on MDMA due to its promise in studies. MDMA, which remains illegal at the federal level, induces euphoria and sociability by increasing levels of neurotransmitters including serotonin and dopamine. Some researchers believe that when taken in a therapeutic setting, it can help patients open up and tolerate revisiting past traumatic events.

But the use of MDMA in therapy is controversial because of its popularity as a recreational drug, and the potential for abuse. Critics also have been concerned about the methodology of drug trials and whether the science supports the high hopes for the treatments.

Elon Musk, who has said he was prescribed ketamine to treat depression, has previously spoken of the benefits of psychedelics, including MDMA. *The Wall Street Journal* reported in 2024 that Antonio Gracias and Steve Jurvetson had consumed drugs with the CEO of SpaceX and Tesla, along with Kimbal Musk.

Other high-profile donors supporting research into psychedelics include David Bronner, CEO of the soap maker Dr. Bronner's, New York Mets owner Steve Cohen and his wife, Alexandra Cohen, and Joby Pritzker, a member of the wealthy Pritzker family that founded Hyatt Hotels.

Support in Washington

President Trump in April signed an executive order to speed up the approval process for psychedelics to weeks, instead of years, for treating illnesses like PTSD and depression. He credited podcaster Joe Rogan for bringing his attention to psychedelics like the root ibogaine, which has been touted as an anti-addiction treatment.

At the event, Trump highlighted the drugs' "life-changing potential for those suffering from severe mental illness and depression, including our cherished veterans." An FDA hearing is scheduled for later this month on the potential therapeutic uses of psychedelics.

Steve and Genevieve Jurvetson, a board member of the Psychodetic Science Funders Collaborative, attended the president's April signing ceremony at the White House.

"After losing a family member to opioid addiction, I dedicated myself to this work because I don't want other families to endure the same heartbreak," she said.

Research into psychedelics was largely banned around 1970 and the substances remained off limits for researchers until the 1990s, when the FDA approved their use in some studies. More well-heeled investors funding research and broader interest from pharmaceutical companies over the last decade have led to better data on how the drugs work in the

human body.

"Now we're starting to see high-quality research studies," said Gerard Sanacora, director of the Yale Depression Research Program, whose research supported the FDA's approval of a ketamine nasal spray to treat depression.

New promise

The Lykos takeover idea was broached with Gracias during a dawn rave at the Burning Man festival in 2024: "I asked Antonio to be a white knight and take it over," said Rick Doblin, a longtime psychedelics advocate and founder of the Multidisciplinary Association for Psychedelic Studies, the nonprofit that created Lykos.

Renamed as Resilient, the pharmaceuticals company has spent the past year working on getting FDA approval and solving problems that regulators had outlined in its first application.

Sanacora, the Yale researcher, said that current research shows clear benefits to psychedelics including MDMA for people with PTSD and depression, but that there can be downsides.

Drug trials involving conventional double-blind studies are a particular challenge with psychedelics. Since the drugs change how patients think and experience the world, it can be obvious to both the patient and the clinician when the patient has taken the drug instead of a placebo, which can influence the data.

"It is very exciting but there still are some hurdles," he said.

For its new application, Resilient conducted a third-party audit of its prior trials to compile new data on adverse events, which had been left out of its earlier application, according to people close to the company. It also ran additional studies, including a Phase I trial launched in April to evaluate the safety of MDMA on healthy adults.

Supporters of psychedelics are putting hope in companies like Resilient getting the green light from regulators.

"A year from now, I hope we'll have multiple FDA-approved psychedelic therapies so patients can safely access treatment under the care of trained medical professionals," Genevieve Jurvetson said.

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NEWS
NUMBERS

100

NUMBER of NHAI-authorized highway plazas that allegedly used unauthorized apps to illegally collect toll money from vehicles without FASTag, according to ED.

1.339 mn

THE NUMBER of missing mobile phones recovered as of September 2026, representing less than 37% of traced devices, according to the CEIR dashboard.

₹7,443 cr

THE AMOUNT foreign investors withdrew from Indian equities in the first week of Sept due to rebounding oil prices, rising US bond yields, and a firm dollar.

64%

THE PERCENTAGE of India's home loan volumes accounted for by tier-II and tier-III cities in 2025, according to a report by SGA PR.

4,000

THE APPROXIMATE number of UK jobs Jaguar Land Rover reportedly plans to cut over the next two years amid falling sales and rising costs.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

UK business minister to meet JLR CEO



Jaguar Land Rover employs about 30,000 people in Britain.

REUTERS

Britain's business minister Jonathan Reynolds said he will meet Jaguar Land Rover's CEO this week to discuss job cuts at the country's biggest carmaker, amid reports it is looking to shed 4,000 roles.

Reynolds told the *BBC* on Sunday that while he wanted to mitigate job losses, the business environment for carmakers was "challenging" in the UK and across Europe.

"If this is about making sure over time that workforce is right to make the business as competitive as possible, that's the conversation we need to have," Reynolds said on Sunday.

JLR, which employs about 30,000 people in Britain and whose largest plant is in Solihull, West Midlands, is owned by India's Tata Motors. It said in a statement it needed to make £1.7 billion of savings over the next two years and as such it would be opening a voluntary redundancy programme.

"We need to adapt to evolving global market conditions," a JLR spokesperson said. The job cuts would be a setback for Prime Minister Andy Burnham, who took office six weeks ago, and has repeatedly said he wants to "reindustrialise" Britain.

REUTERS

IndusInd Bank MD eyes Q2 growth

The difficult phase for the microfinance business is now behind us, with risks playing out favourably, and growth in the segment is expected to return from the second quarter onwards, IndusInd Bank managing director (MD) and chief executive officer Rajiv Anand has said.

IndusInd Bank faced a severe governance and accounting crisis in 2025 centred around its microfinance subsidiary, Bharat Financial Inclusion Ltd (BFIL). The bank reversed ₹674 crore of cumulative interest income recognised incorrectly across fiscal year 2025 (FY25). A further ₹172 crore was disclosed as fraud, where employees falsely reported the sum as fee income in the microfinance business.

PTI



At present, 100% FDI under automatic route is permitted in the tea sector.

ISTOCKPHOTO

Govt weighs FDI in plantations: official

The government is considering liberalising foreign direct investment (FDI) norms in the plantation sector by bringing more commercial crops under the ambit, an official said. The commerce and industry ministry is holding stakeholder consultations on the issue, the official said.

"We are looking for more FDI liberalisation in the plantation sector like banana," the official added.

At present, 100% FDI under automatic route is permitted in the tea sector, including tea plantations, coffee, rubber, cardamom, palm and olive oil tree plantations.

Besides these, FDI is not allowed in any other plantation sector/activity. India has received \$295.23 million FDI in tea and coffee (processing and warehousing coffee), and \$3.93 billion in rubber goods during April 2000 and March 2026.

As per estimates, India is the largest banana producer in the world with over 30 million tonnes annually.

Despite being the largest global producer of bananas, India's exports do not reflect this quantitative evaluation.

PTI

OPEC+ to keep oil output quotas unchanged

The US-Iran conflict has blunted the impact of OPEC+ decisions for the time being

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Major OPEC+ nations stuck with their plan to keep oil production quotas unchanged, while the Iran war continues to shutter vast swathes of output in the Middle East. A sub-group of seven countries led by Saudi Arabia and Russia, which held a monthly video conference on Sunday, will keep targets steady in October after a series of symbolic quota increases, OPEC said in a statement. That's in keeping with the group's roadmap to hold targets flat to the end of the year.

The US-Iran conflict has blunted the impact of OPEC+ decisions for the time being as disruption in the Strait of Hormuz severely reduces oil exports from Persian Gulf nations, though several of them have managed to prop up flows using alternative pipeline routes and covert shuttle runs.

Despite the reduced flows, the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and its allies continued to raise quotas during the war to nominally complete the reversal of output curbs made in 2023, and

potentially give some members extra leeway to bolster output once the fighting subsides.

While the coalition formally has another layer of halted supplies it still needs to restore, doing so will be complicated because many members have seen their production capacity deteriorate since the curbs were announced. The war has made the picture more complex.

Last week, renewed hostilities rocked oil prices, as US President Donald Trump ordered fresh attacks on Iranian facilities and the Islamic Republic retaliated against American bases in the region.

"For now, OPEC+ is moving barrels on paper rather than in the physical market," said Jorge Leon, head of geopolitical analysis at Rystad Energy who previously worked at the OPEC secretariat. "The real impact will come if and when Hormuz fully reopens, when the group may suddenly shift from managing constrained exports to confronting a mounting surplus." The sub-group's next monthly meeting will be on 4 October.

The next priority for OPEC+ is an audit of how much each member can physically produce, to be used in calculating members' production limits for 2027.



REUTERS

Novartis India eyes acquisitions

Pharma company Novartis India Ltd (NIL) plans to pursue disciplined, therapy-aligned acquisitions and deepen its last-mile reach into Tier 2 and Tier 3 markets to drive its next phase of growth, according to the company's annual report. The company's future strategy focuses on five anchor therapy areas: pain management, wellness, women's health, neuroscience, and transplant immunology. It aims to build new avenues for growth by protecting and extending the equity of brands such as Voveran, Calcium Sandoz, Methergin, Tegrital, Myfortic, and Simulect. Vikas Gupta, managing director and chief executive officer, Novartis India, stated that the company is focusing on deepening its reach into non-metro markets where its specialist franchises remain under-penetrated relative to their potential. This expansion is viewed as a direct lever for volume growth.

PTI



Hyundai Motor India is seeing 69% SUV penetration in rural markets.

MINT

Hyundai India eyes 30% rural sales: MD

Hyundai Motor India Ltd is betting big on rural markets, which it expects to contribute around 30% of its total sales in the next three to four years, according to its managing director (MD) and chief executive officer Tarun Garg.

The company, which has 68% of its total sales coming from SUVs overall, is also witnessing SUV penetration of 69% in the rural markets, he said in an interaction.

Hyundai Motor India Ltd (HMIL) is also intensifying its rural focus on network expansion with six out of every ten new outlets being opened in such markets, he added.

"I will not be surprised if in another three to four years we can reach about 30%," Garg said when asked how the company is looking at rural penetration going up, especially with its two upcoming new products—a midsize SUV and a compact electric SUV.

PTI

SBI to hire 12,000 personnel

State Bank of India (SBI) intends to hire about 12,000 personnel and add around 250 new branches to its network in the ongoing financial year, said C S Setty, chairman of the country's biggest lender.

"In terms of recruitment, I think we would be looking at around 11,000 to 12,000 appointments across both clerical and officer cadres this year. This number may vary depending on retirements and emerging requirements, but I expect we should close the year with around 12,000 recruitments," he told PTI in an interaction.

"Last year, we have done fairly large recruitment because we took 1,500 specialist IT officers. This year, we do not need such a large number on the IT (information technology) side," he said. With a workforce of over 2.45 lakh employees as of March 2026, SBI is among India's largest employers.

PTI

NoBroker targets profitability

Unicorn real estate platform NoBroker.com's revenue crossed ₹1,000 crore last fiscal year, and it aims to become profitable in the next 8-10 months, a top company official said.

The proptech startup based in Bengaluru, established in 2013, operates mainly in listing properties for renting, buying, and selling, and does not charge customers any brokerage fees.

In the sector, it offers additional services, such as movers and packers, and manages housing societies through the NoBrokerHood app.

In an interview with PTI, NoBroker.com co-founder and chief executive officer Amit Kumar Agarwal highlighted that the company's revenue grew to ₹965 crore in 2024-25 from ₹888 crore in the preceding year, helping it to reduce losses by 25-30% to around ₹300 crore.

After achieving profitability, Agarwal said the company could consider the IPO.

PTI

How billions in Iranian money passes through U.S. banks

FROM PAGE 1

through American banks in 2024, a figure that some Iran researchers say could be brought down if U.S. banks were more proactive.

"Shadow banking networks are extremely difficult to detect, but by no means is it impossible to track Iran's financial flows," said Elaine Dezenski, a former senior Department of Homeland Security official now at the Foundation for Defense of Democracies, a Washington think tank. "U.S. and correspondent banks are squarely on the hook, and that pressure is only increasing."

U.S. financial institutions say they work closely with the Treasury to enforce sanctions, including by filing legally mandated reports on any suspicious activity that could be linked to Iran.

U.S. officials typically only move to penalize banks if they discover a significant failure to implement a sanctions-compliance program and police transactions. Increasing the pressure on U.S. banks and even many foreign ones could come with downsides, sanctions experts say, including closing a key avenue of insight into Tehran's financial dealings.

Still, the Trump administration has encouraged U.S. institutions in private meetings with bank compliance officials to better monitor Iranian money flows.

"Under President Trump, Treasury has made clear that

compliance with U.S. sanctions and other legal obligations is not optional, and failure to comply will carry consequences. Financial institutions are on notice," said Gene Lange, a senior Treasury official who oversees the department's counterterrorism financing office. The department is now "moving faster and more aggressively than ever to identify, disrupt, and penalize any institution or intermediary that continues to enable business with the Iranian regime."

The Treasury also has published alerts for global banks laying out red flags that suggest shell companies could be using the U.S.-led financial system for Iran. These signs include an opaque ownership structure of a firm based in the U.A.E. or a company registered in Hong Kong that uses a Chinese bank account and has no online presence.

Complex problem

The root of the issue is the correspondent-banking process itself, in which any dollar-denominated transaction anywhere must ultimately be cleared by an American lender. The system gives Washington the ability to monitor most international dollar transactions and cut off users' dollars if necessary, crippling their operations.

While Iran increasingly prefers to do business in Chinese yuan or cryptocurrency to avoid that scrutiny, it still must use dollars sometimes to conduct trade, support Middle Eastern allies and buy restricted technology



Correspondent-banking process is the root of the issue.

REUTERS

and components for its military.

To do so, U.S. officials and researchers say, Iran has built an elaborate shadow banking network that includes shell companies and currency exchange houses in places such as Hong Kong and Dubai.

Typically, those entities avoid opening direct accounts at U.S. banks, which would likely refuse their business. Instead, they tap partners in China, the U.A.E. or elsewhere that maintain correspondent relationships with American banks, U.S. officials and researchers say.

Those institutions then move the money on behalf of Iran's front companies, without disclosing their ties to Tehran, while a U.S. bank settles the transfers.

Iranian officials didn't respond to requests for comment.

China has said it opposes "illegal and unreasonable unilateral sanctions" by Washington and will take necessary measures to

safeguard its interests. In a press briefing following the launch of Operation Economic Outcast, a Foreign Ministry spokesman added that economic warfare could disrupt the global economy.

Hong Kong's government has said it vigorously enforces United Nations sanctions but not those imposed unilaterally by individual nations, which it says violate international law.

The U.A.E. Foreign Ministry didn't respond to a request for comment.

Sensors and circuit boards
A recent real-world example looks like this: an Iranian engineering firm put in an order with a Chinese supplier to buy 150,000 circuit boards and sensors—electronic components that are used in car manufacturing but are also sought by Iran for weapons and drones—according to an invoice viewed by *The Wall Street Journal*.

The invoice from the supplier contained the details of its Chinese bank account, and noted that the \$650,000 payment should be routed via a U.S.-based clearing partner in New York.

The documents viewed by the *Journal* showed that the Iranian engineering firm agreed to make payment via Bank Tejarat, an Iranian financial institution sanctioned by the U.S. Tejarat didn't respond to a request for comment.

But an Iranian bank can't just transfer dollars to a Chinese firm's account via the U.S. In

such a scenario, the payment to the account of the Chinese supplier would likely have to move from a shell company that had access to a foreign bank with a U.S. correspondent banking relationship, researchers say.

It is unclear whether the payment reflected in the invoices viewed by the *Journal* was ultimately made.

Well-oiled system

Correspondent banking is vital to a well-functioning global financial system because it allows lenders to settle cross-border payments without transporting physical cash. When a foreign company transfers funds, the U.S. clearing bank effectively deletes dollars from the foreign company's account and adds them to the other party's.

For U.S. institutions, correspondent services can be very profitable, generating fees or funding through deposits and enabling a bank to provide more services to customers abroad.

The question is whether U.S. banks are doing enough to ensure they aren't clearing transactions that benefit Tehran.

It is a challenge that has long bedeviled Washington. If it enforces restrictions loosely, more transactions get through. But clamping down risks damaging the dollar's dominance, as countries look for alternatives such as China's yuan.

"The more you use the tools, the more you create incentives for alternatives" to the dollar, said Alex Zerden, a former Treas-

ury official who founded financial technology and risk advisory firm Capital Peak Strategies.

In the case recently announced by the Treasury, U.S. authorities stopped short of imposing secondary sanctions on Banque Misr UAE. Instead, the Treasury said it would restrict Misr's Emirati branch from accessing U.S. correspondent accounts.

The restrictions don't go into effect immediately. Misr will have a chance to comment on the Treasury action over 30 days before winding down the U.S. correspondent relationships of its Emirati branch. The Treasury didn't threaten any actions against U.S. banks.

The choice of a less disruptive approach highlights the dilemma facing Treasury officials.

Cutting off a foreign bank from the U.S. has in the past effectively destroyed the foreign institution being targeted, while punishing U.S. lenders could make them rein in their correspondent banking activity. Both could have knock-on effects, either for the economy where the foreign bank is located, or the broader financial system.

"That's why they can't take an all-at-once approach, because it might have ripple effects that are counter to what the U.S. government is trying to accomplish," said Jason Prince, a partner at the law firm Akin Gump and former Treasury sanctions official.

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ARE INTERCITY E-BUSES HAVING THEIR MOMENT?

Operators, lenders and charging companies are finding ways to make long-distance services a viable business

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One Sunday late in 2024, Saurabh Patwardhan was at home in Pune with electric buses on his mind. He was planning to pitch the electric vehicles to his father (and boss) Prasanna Patwardhan, chairman of the 40-year-old Prasanna Group, a family-run bus operating company.

A little nervous, Patwardhan asked his father whether the business, which started in 1988, could run electric buses again. "We had tried our hand at e-buses in 2019, on the Mumbai-Pune route. But our attempt went under in no time," he recalls. Fortunately, Patwardhan Sr. gave his assent. Today, the son, who is a director of Prasanna Purple Mobility Solutions Pvt. Ltd, runs 62 intercity e-buses, and is planning to increase that count to 200 next year.

Patwardhan's bet on electric buses is part of the broader shift on Indian roads and highways. India has quickly become the third-largest e-bus market in the world by sales, with 5,358 e-buses sold in FY26, a 37% increase from the previous fiscal year, according to data from the Vahan portal, the government's registry of new vehicles.

These sales figures are propelled by government-run intracity operations, along with e-bus operators such as GreenCell Mobility-backed, Mumbai-headquartered NueGo, New Delhi-based LeafyBus, Bengaluru's Fresh Bus, the Indian arm of German bus operator FlixBus, which operates in North and South India, Gurugram-based zingbus and Pune's Prasanna Purple Mobility Solutions, which also run private intercity routes.

In a sense, 2026 is an inflection point, because policy support is gradually moving from subsidies for intra-city e-buses to financing benefits for intercity e-buses.

The Union ministry of heavy industries (MHI), the nodal authority for electric vehicles in India, said in April that it is working on a new scheme to provide cheaper loans to e-bus and e-truck operations to boost adoption.

As of May, the scheme was slated to have a corpus of ₹9,852 crore to support 50,000 e-buses and 50,000 e-trucks in five years. More recent discussions on the scheme have also considered financing support for the charging solutions used by these commercial electric vehicles, as reported by *Mint* on 31 August.

This public policy shift comes after more than a decade of government support for intra-city e-buses, with the Faster Adoption and Manufacturing of Electric Vehicles (FAME) schemes, which ran from 2015 to 2024, providing incentives to state and city governments to use electric buses. The Centre's ongoing ₹11,900-crore PM E-Drive, the successor to FAME, has allocated nearly 40% of its outlay towards putting 14,028 new e-buses on the roads of the nine biggest cities in India.

The potential market is huge, with India having around 340,000 intercity buses in 2024, out of a total of around 2 million buses, according to a February 2026 Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) whitepaper.

It is possible, however, that India's intercity e-bus operators are driving into a hobbled ecosystem with myriad challenges, including the high upfront cost of an e-bus—at least twice that of a diesel counterpart—and a lack of charging solutions for heavy commercial vehicles.

Out of the 67,657 public electric vehicle (EV) chargers in the country as of 4 September, according to data compiled by state-run Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd, only 534 (0.7%) have a capacity of 121-240 kilowatts (kW), while just nine (0.01%) have a capacity above 240kW. BHEL, which operates under the ministry of heavy industries, is the nodal agency for charging infrastructure incentives under PM E-Drive.

Superchargers—those with capacity above 240kW—are crucial for e-bus operations. The limited availability of these chargers, among other things, is pushing operators, manufacturers, financiers and charging providers to work together to make intercity e-bus operations viable.

COMPELLING BUSINESS CASE

To be sure, diesel buses still rule the roads, be it for intra-city or intercity travel, and make up the vast majority of India's 2 million buses.

To begin with they are far cheaper: a diesel bus for intercity operations costs



An e-bus plugged into a fast charger, (right) an intercity e-bus at LeafyBus' New Delhi depot stands over the servicing pit and (below) LeafyBus' app that tracks location, battery health and charge of its e-buses. MANAS PIMPALKHARE

around ₹65-70 lakh, while a comparable electric bus will cost ₹1.6-1.8 crore.

While financing is required for both powertrains, an operator can secure a diesel bus with a contribution of ₹3 lakh, while the required contribution rises to at least ₹15 lakh for an electric bus. "So, purchasing 100 diesel buses is a ₹3 crore bill for me, while 100 electric buses would cost at least ₹15 crore up front," Patwardhan told *Mint*.

Diesel buses only need to pick up passengers and move. Fuel can be topped up at any retail outlet, something electric bus operators have to plan for in a d v a n c e . "There is far more planning involved for e-buses—battery size, charging requirements, route planning, etc.—whereas there is greater ease of doing business with diesel buses because everything is standardized," Patwardhan adds. Even with all these disadvantages, e-buses are now seeing some traction, because despite their high cost, the operational economics are too compelling to ignore. Operators such as Patwardhan say there is a saving of nearly ₹5 on every kilometre for an e-bus, compared to a diesel bus. On a daily run of 600 km, that amounts to a saving of ₹3,000, or close to ₹1 lakh a month. And that is why operators are willing to pay nearly three times more to buy an e-bus.

A big factor in the growing traction for intercity e-buses today is a kind of convergence among different stakeholders in the ecosystem. E-bus makers, operators, financiers or lessors and charging solution providers are forming contractual relationships aimed at achieving a common goal: unit economics.

One such relationship is in the supply of electricity. "Commercial mobility is enabled with certain unit economics, which makes the cost of power crucial," says Kartikey Hariyani, chief executive officer (CEO) of ChargeZone, a Vadodra-based charge point operator (CPO). E-bus companies and CPOs that *Mint* spoke with said bus operators can receive electricity at around ₹14-15 per unit if they strike a deal with a charge point operator, against a retail price of ₹24-25 per unit.

"The advantage of tying up with a charge point operator is that the e-bus operator does not have to burn cash up front to invest in land and charging infrastruc-

ture," says Shyamasis Das, who heads the electric mobility research vertical at the Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP), a Delhi-based think tank.

There is a kind of mutual dependence in the relationship because both sides have to sink huge amounts of money into their respective businesses. "A supercharging station with a capacity to park and charge 10 buses requires an investment of about ₹5-7 crore. CPOs are willing to invest in more chargers, but they also want assured demand from e-bus operators to make these chargers viable," explains Hariyani. His company operates 550 supercharging stations.

Another relationship that has developed is between financiers, who have embraced the business model despite the high upfront cost, and operators.

A standard 13.5-metre seater-cum-sleeper electric bus costs ₹1.6-1.8 crore, according to multiple operators. The financier or lessor covers around 80% of the cost, with the operator chipping in with the rest. The operator repays the financier over a 5-8 year period in monthly payments, while also undertaking maintenance and paying manpower salaries using fare revenue.

But it takes a lot of forethought and groundwork to achieve the unit economics needed to make an e-bus operation profitable. "Since intercity e-buses run 500-600 km daily, the planning for charging solutions is critical," says Hariyani.

Patwardhan says that once his company figured out a way to run an e-bus profitably, the path forward became clear. It involved ensuring that every e-bus runs as much as possible to make up for its high upfront cost. "The unit economics are key here. We have figured out that if our asset runs 15,000 km in a month, it can work. For it to run that much, your charging at depots needs to be optimised. Once that is done, the per km cost of operations is ₹4-5 lower for electric buses compared with diesel buses," he explains.

Two kinds of chargers are generally considered by e-bus operators: those installed at both ends of a journey, and opportunity charging facilities located along the route, says Rohan Dewan, founder and CEO of Delhi-based bus operator LeafyBus.

"We have depots on all our routes, so the bus can be charged at the end of every journey," he adds.

LeafyBus operates multiple routes in North India connecting Delhi with cities such as Jaipur and Dehradun. Opportu-

KEY NUMBERS
5,358
Number of e-buses sold in the country in FY26, a 37% jump over FY25. India is now third-largest e-bus market globally by sales.

340,000
Number of intercity buses in India in 2024, out of a total of 2 million buses, according to a recent SIAM whitepaper.

₹11,900 CRORE
Outlay of the PM E-Drive scheme, of which nearly 40% has been allocated for 14,028 new e-buses to run in 9 biggest cities.

nity chargers, located at strategic points along highways, serve as supplementary charging infrastructure, and can typically extend the range of an electric bus by approximately 80-100 km.

But those chargers may not always come into play. While an e-bus has a range of 280-360 km on a full charge, intercity e-bus routes are mostly short: 50-150 km routes are the most common, although some 300-400 km routes are beginning to be covered now.

'SWEATING' FOR THE TOPLINE

After an intercity e-bus has been procured with financing support and planned charging solutions, the next part of the new compact is running the bus—'sweating the asset' in industry parlance—to generate the most revenue.

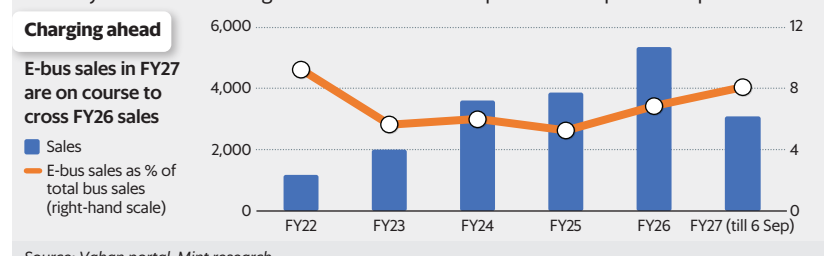
In sweating an e-bus, each operator has its own math. Sudhakar Chirra, founder and CEO of Fresh Bus, told *Mint* that each asset has to run 660 km every day for the company to be profitable.

"The biggest cell we use is a 420kWh one, and it can comfortably ensure that the e-bus runs 350-370 km with no charge in between. Electric buses get the best unit economics when you sweat the asset properly. And it is very important to note that the demand for electric buses is not coming from passengers, it is coming from bus operators," says Chirra.

Fast-charging solutions in depots are crucial for the unit economics to work, Chirra adds, noting that a 60kW charger could theoretically charge a 420kWh battery in seven hours, but that much downtime is not feasible in sweating the asset. His company operates 86 e-buses on routes to Bengaluru, Tirupati and Vijayawada, among other southern cities.

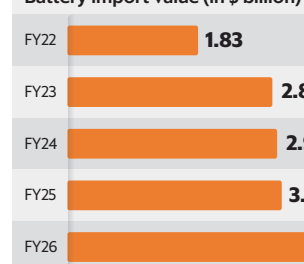
Inflection point

Intercity e-buses are seeing some traction now despite several speed bumps



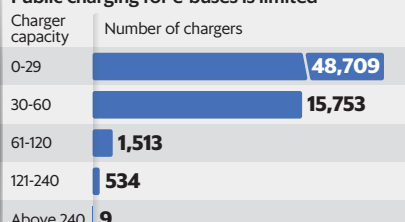
Low battery

Battery import value (in \$ billion)



Capacity constraints

Public charging for e-buses is limited



E-buses, which usually have batteries with capacity over 250 kilowatt-hours, require chargers with over 240 kilowatts of capacity

Source: Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd

Source: Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd

Source: Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd

An e-bus depot, where buses halt between journeys for charging and upkeep, is a good place to gauge the performance of an operator's e-buses.

Mint visited LeafyBus's depot in northeast Delhi, about 20 minutes away from the city's main bus terminal at Kashmere Gate. "We dispatch our buses from here after charging them, and pick up passengers at Kashmere Gate," Dewan told *Mint* over the loud 'whoosh' of an e-bus charging.

The activity of each bus is monitored digitally using cameras and vehicle telematics. "We track everything through an app, and our monitoring teams," he says, pointing at a small digital camera in the driver cabin, and a device for telematics from the vehicle, to track the amount of charge left in the vehicle, its location, and so on.

While operators rely on telematics to improve a vehicle's performance, financiers study the data generated to ascertain if the expensive electric asset they have funded is being used optimally to generate the revenue needed to repay the loan.

"EVs as an asset generate a lot of data, which can be monitored. For financiers and operators that have bet on electric buses, the vehicle needs to be tracked with a sort of P&L (profit and loss) statement, where not just the cost of running the vehicle, but the revenue generated is also monitored," says Alpna Jain, co-founder and chief business officer (CBO) of Drivn, a Gurugram-based EV leasing platform.

"To track the revenues, we need to start by tracking specific routes. And on these routes, we have real time data in terms of

occupancies, ongoing bus schedules that are running, patterns for weekdays and weekends, etc.," says Jain. Her company has developed a data analytics platform to assist e-bus operators.

"These records will be able to show whether an asset is sweating fully, ensuring that the cost of operation remains low and revenues are maximised," Drivn's CBO explains. "By tracking 'asset sweat', lenders can identify underperforming assets early, validate underwriting assumptions and proactively manage portfolio quality, well before any repayment stress becomes visible."

MANUFACTURERS GET ON BOARD

With demand picking up, manufacturers, too, are trying to design buses specifically for intercity travel.

"Intra-city buses are designed for city commutes, shorter routes and high passenger throughput, prioritizing quick acceleration, regenerative braking efficiency and optimal energy utilization in dense urban environments," says Nishant Arya, chairman of JBM Electric Vehicles, which sold the highest number of electric buses (1,282) in FY26, in a written response to *Mint*.

"In contrast, intercity buses are engineered for longer distances, higher cruising speeds and enhanced passenger comfort for longer distances. They require larger battery capacities, and aerodynamically optimised designs to maximise range and efficiency."

However, with additional features vehi-



Could data-driven mutual funds make better stock picks for you?

New fund houses say systematic models remove fund-manager bias from stock selection and make better calls

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India's mutual fund industry has 55 fund houses managing over 1,900 open-ended schemes, including more than 500 actively managed equity funds.

To differentiate themselves, a group of new fund houses is adopting a data-led approach rather than traditional active fund management. By allowing data and fixed rules to guide decisions, this system-driven strategy aims to eliminate fund-manager bias.

The approaches range from using factors based on back-tested market data to using a combination of factors and other data points.

Dynamic factors

Capitalmind Mutual Fund scores its investable universe on five factors—momentum, low risk, quality, profitability and value—but the weight each factor carries shifts with what it calls market-regime classification, said Anoop Vijaykumar, head of equity, Capitalmind Mutual Fund.

This regime interpretation is also entirely data-driven, evaluating metrics such as market breadth, the performance of an equal-weighted index relative to a market cap-weighted index, and how wide factor valuation spreads are compared to historical trends. These dynamic factor weights yield a composite score for every stock, which the model then uses to generate a portfolio.

A market regime refers simply to the current market phase—whether it is rising, falling, or moving sideways. Under this approach, individual factors target distinct stock characteristics: momentum favors equities in an uptrend; low risk selects stocks that are steadier than the broader market; quality targets companies with strong balance sheets; profitability focuses on operational efficiency; and value identifies stocks trading at reasonable valuations relative to their peers.

Some discretion is used if there are any major changes in corporate governance disclosures that are yet to show up in data, or if there is heavy concentration to a single business group.

Data play: beyond the fund manager's instinct

From momentum and quality to news flows, analyst sentiment and job postings, new fund houses are using a wider pool of data to shape their portfolios.

Data-backed strategies

- ▶ Newer fund houses are tapping data to build stock portfolios
- ▶ **Rationale:** reduce fund-manager bias and differentiate their offerings
- ▶ Some use market data to build factor-based models
- ▶ Internal models decide how much weight to assign to each factor
- ▶ Others use a wider range of data signals to build portfolios



Other data points

- ▶ News flow, social media sentiment
- ▶ Order book data
- ▶ Investment flows, stock ownership data
- ▶ Job postings at a company
- ▶ Online sales data from a company

What should investors do

- ▶ Rule-based funds have been widely tested globally
- ▶ Some portfolio allocation to such strategies may be considered
- ▶ But their live track records in Indian markets may be limited
- ▶ Investors may seek to wait for funds to build longer track records

mint
GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

Samco Mutual Fund runs a rules-based, model-driven strategy with momentum as its core factor. "The model tweaks the momentum strategy depending on the market regime. We've also built fundamental checks into the system, so it's momentum first, with a quality overlay," said Umeshkumar Mehta, chief investment officer, Samco Mutual Fund.

"Those checks screen for price-to-earnings multiples, leverage (debt) and free-cash-flow conversion—quality filters that sit inside the model, not outside it," he added.

"Momentum does best in strong bull markets. In sideways, bearish or mean-reverting phases, the model itself trims momentum exposure and rotates into quality or value names. The regime call is systematic, not discretionary," Mehta said.

A mean-reverting phase occurs when price trends reverse—as recent top performers lose steam and lagging stocks recover—a shift that can

cause the momentum factor to underperform.

In the case of NJ Mutual Fund, the primary factor is quality. "We start with the quality filter, where we look at ratios such as return on equity, return on capital employed (the company's internal capital efficiency ratios), debt-to-equity ratio, dividend payout ratio, operating cash flow, etc.," said Nirmay Choksi, executive director, research, NJ Mutual Fund.

Operating cash flow acts as a crucial reality check, confirming whether a company's reported profits reflect actual cash generated by the business. On-paper profits that lack matching cash flows can often signal potential accounting red flags.

"Once we have a set of quality-filtered stocks, we follow a multi-factor adaptive approach. So, depending on the market environment, our model would suggest whether we need aggressive or defensive allocation. For example, in a risk-on environ-

ment, the model may suggest a more momentum-oriented portfolio within our quality basket, while in a risk-off environment, it might switch to a low volatility-oriented portfolio," said Choksi.

A risk-on environment is when the market sentiment is strong and investors are willing to chase returns; risk-off is the opposite: nervier markets in which investors retreat to safer, steadier names.

Alternative data

Jio BlackRock Mutual Fund describes its investment strategy as "systematic active". Under this framework, the fund house evaluates about 400 data signals per Indian stock, actively deploying 30 to 50 metrics per fund. These signals are categorized into distinct factor buckets—such as valuation, quality, sentiment, and fundamentals momentum. "The sentiment bucket... is more about analyst sentiment," said Rishi Kohli, chief investment officer at Jio Black-

Rock Mutual Fund.

It also taps alternative data such as job postings. "If job postings at a company or in a sector are rising or falling, that can provide information about how the company or sector is doing," Kohli said, adding that news and online-sales feeds are also used.

AlphaGrep Mutual Fund combines a multi-factor, adaptive model with other data sources. "We have incorporated all major factors or styles (value, quality, momentum, etc) into our model and then adapt allocations as different factors come in and out of favour," said Bhautik Ambani, chief executive officer of AlphaGrep Mutual Fund.

He added that while the portfolio diversifies across factors, it can be relatively overweight or underweight to certain factors depending on market conditions, which are analyzed by its model.

As for data, the model draws on analyst estimates and earnings revisions, news and social sentiment, order-book and flow & stock ownership data, and analyst call transcripts. "The idea is to capture both long-term drivers and short-term signals that move prices," Ambani said.

Uncharted waters

Many of these strategies are developed and back-tested using historical market data. While these fund houses aim to deliver more resilient, tech-driven models by drawing on broader datasets, their real-world performance across full Indian market cycles remains to be proven.

"Several of these rule-based strategies have been widely tested globally and have demonstrated performance. So there is a case for having some portfolio allocation to data-based strategies. But at the same time, these strategies have been backtested on historical data. So we need to see how these strategies do over longer periods in Indian markets," said Vishal Dhawan, founder of Plan Ahead Wealth Advisors.



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POWER
POINT

DHIRENDRA KUMAR

We welcome your views and comments at
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A ₹10 MF MAY LOOK CHEAP. IT ISN'T: NAV ILLUSION DECODED

About five or six years ago, a neighbour asked me for some help with his mutual fund investments. I went over his portfolio and saw that one midcap fund looked a bit dubious. Instead of handing him the name of an alternative, I encouraged him to use Value Research Online and find one himself.

A few days later, he told me that he had decided that the best alternative to that midcap fund was a liquid fund. When I asked him how he had come to this conclusion, he told me that the liquid fund was rated five-star by Value Research and the NAVs of the two were almost identical: one was ₹37 and the other ₹35.

For those who understand mutual funds, this is an absurd idea, but seemed natural to him. Note, I am not mocking him. He is a successful businessman who started from scratch and found success in just 15-20 years. He understands money well, in the way that an entrepreneur does. And that is what made the episode stick in my mind. If someone like him could arrive at this, then the mistake is not a matter of intelligence. It is a matter of vocabulary.

The price problem

In fact, the blame lies with how all of us familiar with funds talk about NAV. We refer to it as the 'price' of a fund which you pay to 'buy' fund units. If you wanted to buy a car priced at ₹5 lakh and were told to find an alternative, you would start looking for other cars which cost around ₹5 lakh. If NAVs are loosely referred to as the price of a fund, people will bring their mental model of what the word means to mutual funds as well. You can't blame them.

The problem is greater with new fund offers (NFOs), which are priced at ₹10. There is no accounting or regulatory reason for this. A fund could as well start at ₹100 or ₹1,000. When a fund is launched at ₹10 and established funds in that category are at ₹80 or ₹300 or whatever, the car-showroom mental model gets applied in the minds of investors. The new fund looks cheap. The old fund looks expensive. Neither is true.

The simple maths

It's easy to demolish this. Say, there are two funds with identical portfolios, one with an NAV of ₹10 and the other ₹500. You invest ₹5,000 in both—you have 500 units of the first and 10 units of the second. Now the market rises and both portfolios gain 10%. Your ₹5,000 becomes ₹5,500 in both. The only thing that matters is the portfolio, meaning the fund manager's skill and competence. The NAV is irrelevant.

The NFO illusion

Five years ago I said the fault lay with how the industry, salesmen and experts talk about NAV, rather than with investors. Today I would pass harsher judgement. This ₹10 NFO problem is a misunderstanding that is useful to mutual funds and sales people. They know what the ₹10 'price' does to the thinking of investors—so it won't change. Look at when NFOs get launched. They cluster after markets have run up, when investors walk in. That is not a coincidence. A ₹10 unit sold to someone who has never owned a fund is the easiest sale in this business.

There are some exceptions. A few years back, when Indian investors were first presented with the opportunity to invest abroad, all the options were new funds. They were investing in a market which had proven credentials. They were investing through a fund of funds, and the underlying funds had a history. There could still be cases like that. But the test is the same: is there something in the portfolio that you cannot get from an existing fund? If the answer is no, then ₹10 is the only thing being sold.

The red flag

The basic idea is wrong. Low or high NAV is irrelevant as a characteristic on which to base the decision to invest in a fund. In fact, this idea is so thoroughly wrong that it can serve as a good indicator for detecting a fund salesperson or 'advisor' who deliberately misguides you. So remember this: anyone asking you to choose a fund because it has a low NAV is misleading you, and you should stop dealing with that person or outfit.

There are no exceptions to this rule.

Dhirendra Kumar is founder and CEO of Value Research.

How a new compact is driving India's intercity e-bus operations

FROM PAGE 10

cle costs increase. "Intercity e-buses are typically more expensive than intra-city e-buses due to higher battery capacity, extended range requirements and additional comfort and safety features," Arya adds.

This higher cost, however, needs to be seen in context of the benefits it provides in terms of longer battery life, effectively reducing the need for charging, and the total cost of ownership, says Arya.

Operators agree. "An intercity e-bus can cost me around ₹1.80 crore," says

Dewan of LeafyBus. "A low-floor intracity e-bus can cost around ₹1.20 crore. That's a third lower."

This higher cost, however, needs to be seen in context of the benefits it provides in terms of longer battery life, effectively reducing the need for charging, says Arya.

Other manufacturers that are in various stages of developing and deploying intercity e-buses, according to their public statements, include Tata Motors, Volvo Eicher Commercial Vehicles and Hinduja Group's Switch Mobility. The new emerging business model for e-bus oper-

ators will develop as global battery prices decline and charging technology matures and becomes widespread in India. However, experts say the foundational contractual relationships that have been formed today are likely to remain.

"Even if chargers are wide-

spread and abundant, say two decades down the line, e-bus operators will continue utilising the services of charge point operators," says Das of CSEP. "And those operators that have the investment appetite and long-term plans will find merit in setting up their own captive chargers."

How different assets are taxed?

This table shows the post Budget 2024 capital gains tax treatment across different assets. As a uniform rule, LTCG on all assets except debt funds is now 12.5%, and STCG on assets where STT is paid is 20%, while assets without STT continue to be taxed at slab rates.



	Holding period for LTCG	STCG tax rate	LTCG tax rate
Equity MFs, ETFs and stocks	>12 months	20%	12.5%*
Gold ETFs	>12 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Reits/InvITs	>12 months	20%	12.5%
Listed bonds	>12 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Debt MFs**			
Bought before 1 April 2023	>24 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Bought 1 April 2023 onwards	NA	Slab rate	Slab rate
Gold MFs*, physical gold, overseas MFs, FOFs	>24 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Foreign equity, international ETFs	>24 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Real estate	>24 months	Slab rate	Bought after 23 July 2024: 12.5% Bought before 23 July 2024: lower of 12.5% without indexation and 20% with indexation

*On gains above ₹1.25 lakh. **includes funds that have invested over 65% of proceeds in debt and money market instruments. MF: Mutual funds; ETFs: Exchange-traded funds; Reits: Real Estate Investment Trusts; InvITs: Infrastructure Investment Trusts; FOF: Fund of Funds; NA: Not Applicable. All rates are base; surcharge and cess extra. *gold MFs that invest in an underlying gold ETF. Those without an FOF structure qualify as long-term asset after 1 year. Source: Mint Research

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

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Equity allocation should reflect your goals

Feroze Azeez

I started investing aggressively when the markets were doing well. Now I'm uncomfortable with the amount of equity exposure I have. Should I reduce it even if my long-term goal is still several years away?

—Name withheld on request

When you started investing can make a big difference to how you view your portfolio today. For simplicity, think of investors who started before 2020 and those who began investing more heavily after 2020. If you started after 2020, you have seen a lot happen in a relatively short period. Markets recovered strongly after the pandemic and continued to rise, with equities doing particularly well through much of 2024. The Nifty 50 reached a high in September 2024, after which markets became more volatile and started moving up and down more sharply.

For some investors, this may have changed how comfortable they feel with risk. A portfolio that seemed perfectly comfortable when markets were rising may now feel too heavily invested in equity. Those who started investing



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before 2020, on the other hand, may have already experienced more market cycles and seen how equity can reward investors who stay invested over the long term.

Start with goals

So, if you are wondering whether you have too much money in equity, it may help to look beyond what the market is doing today and focus on what you are investing for and when you will need the money. For example, if you have a retirement goal that is still 20 years away, there is a strong case for maintaining a higher equity allocation. Depending on your return expectations, financial situa-

tion and comfort with risk, 60-80% in equity could be considered, with the rest in debt. Equity has historically delivered better growth over longer periods, although a mix of equity and debt can make the portfolio more balanced.

Match the horizon

The approach needs to be different if you are investing for a short-term goal. If you are putting money into equity for something you may need soon, it makes sense to bring down that exposure and move a larger portion towards debt or other relatively stable options. Depending on your tax bracket and circumstances, arbitrage funds may also be considered.

Medium-term goals, on the other hand, need a middle ground. Say you want to buy a

house in seven years. You may still want equity to provide growth, while debt can provide greater stability as the goal gets closer. In such cases, 50-70% equity could be considered based on the time available and your comfort with market movements.

Build a buffer

There is another part of the equation that investors often overlook. An adequate emergency fund, along with the right health and term insurance in place, will ensure that you are less likely to sell your equity investments when an unexpected expense comes up. So, feeling uncomfortable with your equity exposure does not necessarily mean you need to reduce it. What matters more is whether your portfolio still makes sense for the goals you are working towards. Review it regularly, look at your overall asset allocation and diversification, and make changes when goals or circumstances change.

Feroze Azeez, joint chief executive, Anand Rathi Wealth.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at
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OUR VIEW



Economics 101: mauled again by Donald Trump

The US President's call for a Fed rate cut and tirade against trade deficits made the world sit up. An economy, however, can't be run by all-caps command. Or as a business for that matter

It is one of the biggest ironies of life that two of the most important jobs in the world—that of a parent and of the president of the world's most powerful country—do not call for prior training. In both cases, the hope is that one will learn on the job. In both, the stakes are high; as is the cost of failure. But there is one key difference. The damage one can do as a knowledge-proof parent is largely limited to one's children. In the case of White House occupants, however, to rephrase Shakespeare a bit, the harm that men do lives after them, while the good is oft interred with their bones.

What history makes of the legacy of the 47th President of the United States of America cannot be foretold, but our hearts must go out to future scholars trying to puzzle out his policy intent, proclamations and outcomes. Even by the Donald Trump presidency's own record, an outlier among outliers, the US president's latest call for the Federal Reserve to cut its policy rate, or else—particularly the 'or else' part—has been a stunner. In an all-caps post on his Truth Social platform, Trump said: "Lower the rate or I'll stop trading with countries with which we have a deficit." Paradoxically, this threat was made after surprise data showed that US employers had added 162,000 non-farm jobs in August, more than seven times that month's payroll gain in 2025. Even nodding familiarity with Economics 101 would lead anyone to read that as a sign of a strong economy, not a weak one in need of the monetary stimulus of cheaper credit. Especially with US inflation having run above the Fed's target rate of 2% for more than half a decade. But Trump's perspective differs. The strength of the US economy, in his view, means it can

afford to reduce rates right away. Theory must not get in the way of "True Economic Greatness," he posted, and since growth "does not cause inflation" (as he asserted in all caps), the Fed must cut borrowing costs to the "lowest rate" (in caps) of "any country in the World." Apart from the fact that interest-rate policy is beyond the purview of the political leadership and must be set by an independent central bank, Trump's latest gambit is of a piece with his past efforts to push the Fed into untimely and risky rate cuts. The reality is that cheaper credit is likely to make the US economy overheat, stoke inflation further and eventually slow economic growth down. That AI, robots, etc, will enable a positive outcome is a fantasy best not tested. The usual trade-off of price stability versus payroll growth still holds, even if technology alters the details of its dynamics.

As for trade, it is true that America runs a huge deficit with the world, with Vietnam, Mexico, Taiwan, China, Thailand, South Korea, Germany and India making up the bulk of it. But this only reflects US consumption being way ahead of its savings. America lives well beyond its means, with the dollars earned by others invested or loaned right back. Global demand for US federal debt assets keeps a lid on its cost of capital, for which it must largely thank the dollar's unique privilege as the world's reserve currency under the post-Bretton Woods framework of international payments. For the rest of the world to be content being paid in dollars, though, America must ensure that its dollar does not get debased. In its own interest, it must let the Fed do its job. To a business manager, a trade deficit may look like a blotch of red ink, a glaring loss. But that's not how trade and capital flows work.

Why Indian languages demand standard Roman transliteration

Variously spelt names can get entangled in red tape. Standardized forms could ease life for millions



NITIN PAI is co-founder and director of The Takshashila Institution, an independent centre for research and education in public policy

There are four variants of the name Subramanya: Subramanyam, Subramani and Subramanya, in addition to the Sanskrit original that I will spell as Subraman-yuh. The Four Subramanyams cause no problems for themselves or for society in most Indian scripts, for they are unambiguously spelt as they are pronounced.

When expressed in the Latin alphabet though, the variants proliferate: from the common ones like Subrahmanyam, Subrahmanyam, Subramaniam, Subramanian and Subramannian that you will come across in top government offices, to Subramonium, Subramanium and others that remind you of chemistry, to exotic ones like Subramoney, Soobramoney, Soobermoney, Soubramanion and Soebrahamjam that belong to our colonial cousins. And this is before numerologists get involved and recommend things like adding some more 'u's and a double 'n' to make the concerned name bearer excel in entrance examinations.

Indians are okay with this variety of spelling, although the Subramaniam couple I know gives me some difficulty. Addressing 'Dear Mr Subramanian and Mrs Subramaniam' feels like writing to two halves of two different couples.

All this pluralism stops being funny when spellings meet the state. Subramaniam has to appear before a notary and sign an affidavit saying that the Sub-

ramaniam who passed the Tamil Nadu school leaving exam and the Subramanian who has a birth certificate by that name are one and the same. This has to be published in two newspapers whose cuttings have to be produced, along with the original certificates and affidavit, while applying for a passport. If this Subramaniam's father was Sreenivasan in one document and Srinivasan in another, then more affidavits, notaries and newspaper advertisements follow.

Not just individuals, names of streets and places have variations too, which you discover when going through your third KYC process. Over 15 years ago, the unique identification (UID) project came up with an elegant solution for the problem by assigning each individual a number that could be validated biometrically. Unfortunately, controversy, politics and usage changed Aadhaar from a number to a card, with Subramaniam's name spelt using the document used for UID enrolment.

Over the past few months, many people have had to make the rounds of notaries and government officials to sort out discrepancies noticed by the Election Commission as it conducted its Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. The spelling business is thus at best an inconvenience and at worst grounds for disenfranchisement. The economic cost of having multiple spelling variants have not been calculated, but they are immense and make normal life unnecessarily difficult. Documentation anxiety accompanies every interaction with banks, hospitals, government offices and delivery companies. A friend once had to swear in an affidavit that Mr Shailendra Nayak and Shailendra Nayak are one and the same person to the best of his knowledge just to clear a shipment.

Standardized spelling is a form of public infrastructure. Independent India did not build this for the Latin/Roman alphabet. China, Malaysia, Indonesia and Vietnam are among those that did, following decolonization. Germany

and South Korea reformed spellings more recently. The complex world of the Chinese language—with its pictograms, dialects and tones—was simplified by the *hanyu pinyin* system, which standardizes the spelling of all words.

The use of the Roman script has the added advantage of making the language easier for others to learn. In the 1970s, Malaysia and Indonesia not only harmonized spellings (which were different because of their English and Dutch colonial history), but practically did away with the older Arabic-derived Jawi script. Vietnam pragmatically standardized the French-influenced Roman script imposed by its colonial masters. India, however, adopted a *laissez-faire* approach to spellings, which is not a good thing when it comes to infrastructure. Allowing everyone to set up railway tracks of any width makes a national railway system hard to run.

There is a case for creating a standard Roman transliteration scheme for Indian words. It is not technically difficult: unlike Chinese and Vietnamese, we do not need a number of accent marks to distinguish several tones for each sound. There are a handful of sounds like the *zh* in the Tamil (actually Tamil) word '*kazhagam*,' that do not have straightforward equivalents, but we have established usage that can be standardized. Roman spellings can co-exist with Indian scripts. Apart from making life easier for Subramaniams, Indians will be able to learn other Indian languages without having to learn a new script. The Indian Army, with troops from across the country, already enables communications in Hindi by writing it in the Roman script.

A standard for spellings is best left as a recommendation. It should not be imposed. People should have the option to adopt it because it is simple, phonetically accurate and makes life more convenient. There will still be parents who want to name their son Zhubhramanjam. They should be free to do so.



JUST A THOUGHT

Central bank independence is precious. It can be taken for granted in benign times, but it is tested when times get tough. And we still have tough times ahead of us.

KEVIN WARSH

MY VIEW | MODERN TIMES

Why we should trust the RSS when it says good things

MANU JOSEPH



is a journalist, novelist and screenwriter. His latest book is 'Why the Poor Don't Kill Us.'

Those who dislike the saffron crowd often lampoon their silliest political habit, which is that they hold the Congress accountable for what Jawaharlal Nehru did to India's economy. But the anti-saffrons have a similar problem—they hold the entire history of the Hindu movement against the present of its mother ship, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS).

Every time it asserts the right of Muslims to exist as equal Indians, anti-saffrons caution us not to believe them, that this is all an act. As it happened a few days ago when the RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat told thousands of people in New York that a Hindu who believes Muslims should be driven out of India "cannot remain a Hindu." He also said that diversity is in India's "DNA." He portrayed Hindu deities not as celestial figures, but as archetypes of ideal humans, and demons as the evil within us all. He also reminded us that electoral politics is flawed, and authoritarians can't stitch together a nation.

This is the sort of thing all activists with

inner beauty say. But anti-saffrons say it is naive to take the RSS chief at his word. (I am struggling to avoid nonsensical terms like 'left' and 'right,' which is complicated by avocado-eaters no longer being a political constituency.)

They say he is posturing for the West. But he has been saying the same things here to provincial audiences who are not accustomed to hearing things like "The day it's said Muslims aren't wanted, Hindutva won't remain." A tired argument of some is that he wants Muslims to remain in India so that Hindus can fight them instead of their own. What is more persuasive is that some intellectuals want the RSS to be frozen in the past so that they have someone to condemn and thus be reassured of their own virtues.

If all living things and what they form can evolve, the RSS can too. In fact, it has excellent reasons to do so. It has, after all, achieved its end. Hindu upper castes who felt oppressed by Westernized Anglophile gentry went to war using wounded Hindu pride to unite middle castes and other social rungs to create a society where Hindus are more equal than others. What the RSS is trying to say is that it's traditional but evolving. And whether people say it explicitly or not, evolution involves something dying. Maybe

like scientific progress, the RSS too has advanced, one funeral at a time. Also, maybe the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) that it mentors or used to mentor for politics has grown too big, and the mothership is not enjoying all aspects of this tremendous success, and wants to present an alternate Hindu intellectual view that career politicians are not saying.

There is a reason why, without hailing the RSS as a vast humanitarian organization, we should trust the spirit of Bhagwat's words.

Morally clear statements about Muslims from powerful Hindu leaders, even if they are just words, contribute immensely to how ordinary people perceive their world. Good things are so rare and faint that when they do come, we must not muddle them. For a Hindu public figure to say the things he does could potentially carry a cost. So, to think that the RSS would pretend love for Muslims to improve its image is plain ridiculous.

I accept there are some good reasons to be dismissive of speeches. What matters is

what's on the ground. The social security of Muslims in India has broken down. There are several thugs on social media with apparent allegiance to some Hindu organizations who overtly threaten Muslims, Dalits, fashionable women and whoever they deem as foes, and there is rarely any police action against them.

One man has just claimed he broke someone's head during the cockroach protest and that some leaders have ensured he is not in jail. The violence of cow vigilantes continues.

RSS statements may be influential, but not always. There is a fact that the powerful never articulate—that they are not as powerful as people think, that they have limited control over people. Men who believe in the ideal human may not know how to deal with 'demons.' An RSS that wants a good global reputation might find it needs to work harder at it.

Even so, there are good reasons why we must trust the words of the RSS's top leader, apart from the fact that there is circumstantial evidence that he means all that he has

been saying. His speeches represent hope in a difficult and dangerous world.

Like Western 'right-wing' formations, India's Hindu movement grew popular by making a large part of a majority behave like a persecuted minority. Now, the world's most consequential Hindu organization is shedding old grouses and showing the magnanimity of being self-assured.

Also, there is a reason why it is Bhagwat who has been saying socially modern things, rather than leaders of the political face of the Hindu movement, the BJP. Since the party has to contest elections, and much is at stake, its leaders seem to overrate the risk of saying decent things.

Modern India offers throbbing evidence that electoral democracy is flawed, and that what India needs is a counterforce through public pressure groups. The triumph of this year's student protests was proof that some movements can compensate for the failings of institutions and keep elected governments in check. In its own way, the RSS has been performing this role behind the scenes, and lately it has started doing it more openly. We need that. It would be interesting, though, if we can guess what the maximum size of India's Muslim population is that would sustain these sounds of harmony.

If all living organizations can evolve, it can too. In fact, it has excellent reasons to



MY VIEW | GENERAL DISEQUILIBRIUM

MINT CURATOR

Student protests have put India's welfare economy under the lens

Unconditional cash transfers are rising but it's unlikely the youth will accept these as compensation for weak job prospects

**RAJRISHI SINGHAL**

is a senior journalist and author of 'Slip, Stitch and Stumble: The Untold Story of India's Financial Sector Reforms' @rajrishisinghal

Student protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi did not only secure the resignation of India's former education minister Dharmendra Pradhan but should also be credited with other achievements. The first, and interesting, outcome is how it has helped revive students' abilities to articulate concerns about the education system's structural flaws, exercise agency over their own future and re-assert their civil rights while interrogating authority. Second, it once again underscored the contradictions and paradoxes that bedevil India's society and economy. But, more importantly, it has refocused attention on an issue that has been left hanging in the air: can welfare economics paper over structural fault-lines?

These three issues need expanding. The past decade has witnessed the infantilization of students and suppression of their political rights. While the state encourages them to participate in the country's largest political activity—elections of all kinds—it simultaneously uses repressive measures to restrict other forms of political expression. Many ruling party apparatchiks have used this as an excuse to persecute politically-conscious students; some even interpreted it as a licence to unleash violence on students, as experienced in some leading universities.

The state perhaps has an instinctive aversion to mass student movements, given how some of these have historically managed to wreak political changes—1968 in Paris forced the Charles de Gaulle government to bring in sweeping social changes, 1998 in Jakarta ended the 32-year reign of authoritarian president Suharto, the 1970 campus protests against America's expanding wars in Vietnam and Cambodia fuelled nationwide anti-war sentiment. The spark lit by students in Delhi has now engulfed many other college and university campuses. It has even inspired school children in various states to demand better infrastructure.

The student agitation has also drawn attention to a dreary paradox: the Indian economy's fast-growing output and rising number of billionaires alongside a bulging army of educated-unemployed youth and widening inequality. Gross domestic product (GDP) growth of 7.8% for the first quarter of 2026-27—in the midst of a global conflict, rising prices, the private sector's stubborn reluctance to invest and a deteriorating job market—re-asserts this conundrum. Leaked question papers for medical entrance exams may have provided the initial catalyst for this year's student uprising, but it also provided a platform for many other students to express their frustrations with a creaky, corrupt education system and a constricted job market.

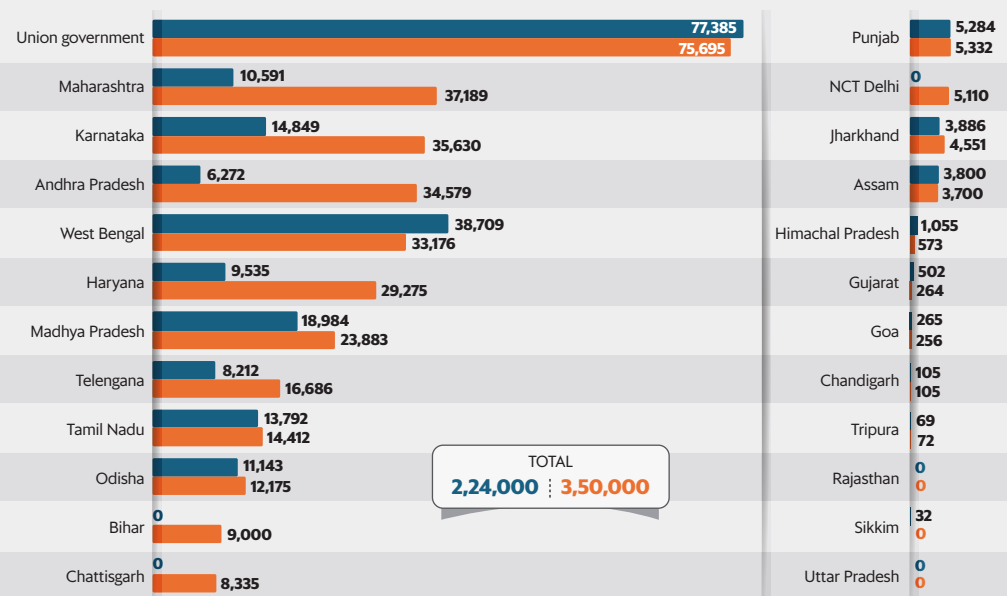
Millions of Indians between the ages of 15 and 29 are either unemployed, forced into informal jobs or stuck in low-paying inferior jobs. India's demo-

Cash transfers are on the rise

While the Centre has marginally reduced its outlay for these, most states have enlarged theirs.

Unconditional cash transfers by the Centre and states (in ₹ crore)

Actual transfers in 2024-25 Budget estimate for 2026-27



Source: Project Deep, various state government budgets (data not exhaustive)

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graphic dividend is fast turning into a liability.

It is also a political liability and the political class recognizes it. Ironically, though, instead of fixing structural flaws, politicians have resorted to an aggressive spinning of the welfare dial. About 10 Indian states have already added a new category for resource transfers: educated unemployed youth.

This is in addition to unconditional cash transfers (UCTs) to women and farmers, which have now become a generalized trend. With the state failing to provide basic services, as laid out in the Constitution's Directive Principles of State Policy, UCTs have become necessary to stave off poverty,

supplement basic income and sustain essential consumption. Most of these cash transfers are targeted at specific demographic cohorts (such as women, though some are also universal), but are essentially unconditional with no restrictions on how the money is spent. According to the *Economic Survey* for 2025-26, the number of states with UCTs increased five-fold between 2022-23 and 2025-26. Budgetary allocations for women-centred UCTs alone across states are now close to ₹2 trillion.

Cynicism sets in when UCTs are launched with a view to harvest only electoral dividends. Maharashtra's Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana, for example, was launched in June 2024, five months ahead of the state's assembly elections in November 2024; once the incumbent coalition of parties returned to power, around 40% of the beneficiaries were removed. In West Bengal, a newly-elected political dispensation is removing about 60% of the beneficiaries from an existing women-centred UCT scheme and trying to replace it with a new one in an attempt to consolidate and expand its political patronage.

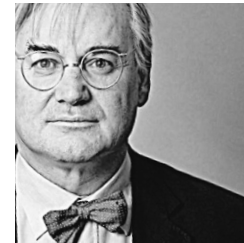
Yet, there is no denying that UCTs have become indispensable for some vulnerable segments of Indian society, such as women in certain socioeconomic categories or distress-prone farmers. According to non-profit organization Project Deep, "UCTs foster dignity, agency and independence, driving outcomes in gender, education, healthcare and other critical areas."

It is also true that UCTs provide much-needed temporary funding for the educated-unemployed. But that cannot be a permanent solution, especially if it effectively replaces the state's long-term investment in the enabling infrastructure for sustainable economic growth and job creation.

It seems unlikely that India's restless youth will quietly accept their lot as a *fait accompli*, settle for UCTs rather than jobs that provide opportunities for life improvement, forsake protests or demonstrations, and still vote for the same political party. In reality, all of this actually looks like a risk with a very long tail.

Nuclear shipping must not be turned into another arms race

Excluding China from talks on uranium-run ships is self-defeating

**DAVID FICKLING**

is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering climate change and energy.



China is the world's biggest shipbuilder and container-port operator.

PTI

What if we could revive the moribund US shipbuilding industry, spur investment in atomic energy, make ocean freight faster and cheaper, and eliminate one of the world's biggest sources of carbon emissions—all at once? Better still, what if we could poke China in the eye at the same time?

That is the vision behind a proposed renaissance of nuclear merchant shipping. The US government is reportedly planning to sign a public-private partnership with Core Power, a UK-based company planning to launch a nuclear-powered cargo ship in 2028. Such vessels will "change the game and DOMINATE China", US Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy wrote on X. Some 25 nations meeting at the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) in Washington last week agreed to work on plans to let uranium power the sort of giant ocean-going vessels that ship toys, furniture, cars and raw materials around the world. China was not among them.

That is a fatal omission. Nuclear merchant shipping is indeed an idea whose time has come. But turning it into collateral damage in the bathtub-battleship contest between Washington and Beijing is the surest way to ensure it never happens.

One cannot write the rules of nuclear merchant shipping to exclude the world's biggest exporter, shipbuilder, container-port operator and producer of reactors, as the main barriers are not technological or economic, but regulatory and political.

Consider how close we could be to a deal. No scientific breakthroughs are needed to make uranium-powered vessels work: Nuclear submarines have been plying the seas since 1955; about 160 ships and submarines carry reactors onboard.

The economics are yet to be proven, but could be compelling. Nuclear ships can steam far quicker than conventional ones, which typically slow down to conserve fuel. By a rough calculation, an atomic vessel moving at 25 knots could in theory carry 50% more containers between Rotterdam and Shanghai than a conventional one at 16 knots. Nuclear vessels might cost significantly more, but an operator would need far fewer of them, potentially bringing down its cost per container.

An atomic shipping industry could navigate around the world's many anti-nuclear holdouts. An agreement would not need many countries to sign on. The world's top 20 ports span just 11 countries and handle nearly half of all container traffic. The biggest ships are owned by a handful of companies based in Switzerland, Denmark,

France, China, Japan and South Korea. The industry itself revolves around a few global trunk routes that feed traffic into smaller ports. The current generation of mega-container ships could probably be replaced with a fleet of less than 500 nuclear vessels.

That might help the climate too, especially if the smaller feeder vessels are battery-powered. The world's ship fleet emits about as much carbon dioxide as the whole of Japan. Nuclear-plus-batteries might not replace every vessel, but it is a plausible path to reduce the industry's carbon footprint by more than two-thirds, by my estimates.

Regulation is where it gets fiendishly difficult, however. Almost all reactors now are either inside a sovereign state or aboard a heavily armed military vessel. A nuclear merchant fleet would change that, putting hundreds of them into international waters vulnerable to pirates and armed groups. A conventional crew would need to expand to include a group of highly trained and paid nuclear engineers, plus potentially an armed security force to deter hijackers.

At that point, the legal, insurance and security landscape would look vastly different from the present one. Almost a fifth of the container traffic at US ports is on Chinese-built vessels. Nervous at the prospect of a Chinese nuclear containership docking in the port of Los Angeles? How about adding Chinese nuclear engineers and armed Chinese guards to protect its potentially hazardous power plant?

The problem isn't intractable. At the height of the Cold War, US President Eisenhower negotiated with the Soviet Union to develop just such a set of international rules and inspections for civilian nuclear technology. The IAEA ultimately grew out of those discussions. It has been largely successful over seven decades in turning nuclear technology from a weapons system into a civilian industry providing clean energy and medicine for the benefit of humanity.

Repeating that now will require extraordinary levels of trust between the world's major trading nations. But such trust is increasingly scarce and President Donald Trump's tariff wars are doing their best to undermine what remains. There is no plausible future for nuclear merchant shipping without China's buy-in. Turning it into an arms race with Beijing is the best way to ensure it never happens.

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THEIR VIEW

Oh, for a few dollars less: RBI is faced with a forex flood

MYTHILI BHUSNURMATH



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Be careful what you wish for' is an old (and wise) saying. Getting what you wish for can bring unexpected results. And, at times, lead to unwanted outcomes. The saying fits the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) recent foreign currency non-resident deposit (bank), or FCNR(B), scheme to garner additional dollars to a T.

Rebind to 8 June. Faced with unrelenting foreign portfolio outflows and prolonged weakness in the rupee, RBI turned to its tried and tested strategy when faced with trouble on the external front. It turned to overseas Indians, luring them with attractive sweeteners, even as it prodded banks to resort to tactics it would have frowned upon had they dared to replicate them at home. It virtually gave them *carte blanche* to extend loans against existing dollar deposits to fund fresh FCNR(B) deposits, a process euphemistically called raising 'leveraged' deposits, though, in truth, it was more akin to 'evergreening', albeit by another name.

The net result? Despite ending its special

foreign exchange swap facility for FCNR(B) deposits on 31 August, a full month ahead of its original end-date, 30 September, inflows at \$136.4 billion have far surpassed initial expectations. According to provisional data released by RBI, FCNR(B) deposits accounted for the bulk of the inflows at \$127.2 billion, while overseas foreign currency bonds brought \$5.3 billion and external commercial borrowings \$3.9 billion.

The last time RBI attempted something like this was in 2013 when fears that the US Federal Reserve would raise interest rates led to what came to be known as the Taper Tantrum and put the rupee under severe pressure. This time round, RBI went further. Not only did it liberalize rules on the maximum interest rates that banks could offer on FCNR(B) deposits, it exempted these deposits from statutory requirements like the cash reserve ratio (CRR) and statutory liquidity ratio (SLR). It also allowed banks to exclude such deposits from the 'adjusted net bank credit' calculation while determining their priority-sector loan obligations.

If the hope was that these short-term foreign currency inflows would give RBI the firepower (forex reserves) needed to intervene in the market to prevent the rupee from depreciating too far, and too fast, its hope

has been realized. Forex reserves, which had touched a low of \$681.4 billion in the week ended 22 May, rose to a record high of \$729.3 billion in the week ended 21 August; an increase of almost \$48 billion in just three months.

On the exchange rate front, though, the outcome has been less encouraging. The domestic currency has remained largely range-bound in the ₹95-96 to the dollar range.

If that's not sobering enough, the reality is the very success of the scheme has brought a host of problems in its wake; problems that RBI as the central bank should have anticipated. But, unfortunately, seems to have over-looked. Consequently, fears expressed by some of the more prescient observers that the scheme would prove both hasty and costly now seem to be coming true.

Consider. Apart from the hedging cost that has to be borne by RBI, and eventually by the taxpayer, RBI is now faced with a huge increase in systemic liquidity. That too at a

time when liquidity is already in surplus (10 of the 23 initial public offerings in August received bids of 100 times the shares on offer) and inflationary pressures are rising, globally and domestically.

Related to the surge in liquidity is the sudden increase in bank deposits (estimated at about ₹12 trillion), thanks to the conversion of dollar inflows into rupees. This (artificial?) increase in system liquidity, akin to a sugar rush, has a number of far-reaching and damaging implications. Faced with so much liquidity, banks are likely to start chasing loans in a bid to deploy excess funds. We've already seen credit growth surge to nearly 20%. And we know what happens when banks lend hand-over-fist: Higher non-performing assets some months down the line.

To be sure, RBI can use a combination of tools to mop up excess liquidity—increase the cash reserve ratio, conduct open market operations, issue market stabilization bonds and so on. But each of these has a cost. They

will raise interest rates, impacting the credibility of a central bank that has all along refused to heed warning signals.

Remember, FCNR(B) deposits have only bought us time. They might have bailed us out, but only for the moment. They have to be repaid, and in dollars. Let's not fool ourselves about the motives of overseas Indians in responding to RBI's overtures.

During the 1991 Gulf War, panic withdrawals of foreign currency deposits by overseas Indians added fuel to fire, possibly hastening the crisis. On top of all this is the very real possibility that the surge in liquidity will stoke inflationary pressures in a scenario where inflation is already rising.

In effect, all that RBI has done is that it has kicked the can down the road; it has postponed the day of reckoning. Instead of addressing the cause of the problem by curbing excess demand (reflected in the country's current account deficit) through a rise in interest rates, it chose to address the symptom—a weakening currency.

It is a telling commentary that at a time when yields and interest rates are rising all over the world, for reasons that are far from clear, India's central bank alone seems to believe in 'Indian exceptionalism.' The world doesn't.

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